

**DUNGEON
CRAWLER CARL**
ROLEPLAYING GAME



RULES FOR SURVIVAL





DEGREES OF SUCCESS & FAILURE

ROLL & TYPE	EFFECT
Natural 20: Critical Hit	Attack: Roll twice as many base damage dice, and then add your Stat Mod and other bonuses. Evade: Gain Advantage on your next Attack Action against that foe. Non-Combat: You achieve the best possible result.
Succeed by 10+: Amazing Success	Attack: You deal bonus damage equal to F. Evade: Gain Advantage on your next Attack Action against that foe. Non-Combat: You did it quickly, quietly, left no trace, etc. Longer projects done quickly give crawlers extra time before level collapse.
Succeed by 0–9: Standard Success	Your Action worked. No bonuses.
Fail by 1–2: Near Miss Fail	Attack: GM announces “Near Miss,” encouraging players to use an Intervene Action. Non-Combat: Fail or succeed with complications.
Fail by 3–9: Standard Fail	Attack: You miss. Evade: You get hit. Non-Combat: Fail or succeed with consequences.
Fail by 10+: Major Fail	Attack: You miss badly - drop an item, need to reload, or suffer the Take Down Debuff. Evade: You get hit and suffer bonus damage equal to F. Gain a Minor Injury post-combat. Non-Combat: You fail and waste time, materials, or ruin tools.
Natural 1: Critical Fail	Attack: You miss terribly — hit a friend, break your weapon, or suffer the Stunned Debuff. Evade: You get hit hard and suffer twice as much damage. Gain a Major Injury post-combat. Non-Combat: You achieve the worst possible outcome.

PATCHING THE RULES

You might find a rule that doesn't work at your table. Maybe you handed out some overpowered gear, or your tactically minded players are making easy work of foes that should be more challenging. As the GM, you can always patch the rules. Don't worry, it happens in *Dungeon Crawler Carl*.

Before you patch the rules, try them first. Then really think about what's not working. Is combat too easy because you didn't throw enough foes at them, or did the players find a way to exploit a combo of options? Give it a little time and see if your hunch holds up.

Once you've identified a problem, look for a rules tweak. Game designers often prefer small changes over large ones. If an Attack Spell is too weak, you could reduce its cost or increase its damage, but doing both might be too much. If a weapon dominates every fight, try giving a few enemies a resistance to it rather than nerfing the weapon outright. You can always patch things again after another session or two if the change hasn't fixed the problem.

When you're ready to patch the rules, consider waiting until the end of the day or the end of the floor, since those are natural break points. Either a Borant employee (Cascadia or otherwise) or the AI can announce it with a grand message or tuck it into a bureaucratic chat. You could also wait for the players to get tired of things being too easy. It can be fun for the players to get in a few solid wins before you change the rules on them. They may even race to use an exploit a few more times before it gets patched.

Finally, keep a record of what you changed. If you increase dagger damage, jot it down in your private notes or a doc you can share with the players, so everyone remembers.



RULES FOR SURVIVAL



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RULES FOR SURVIVAL

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WELCOME TO THE DUNGEON

Or, more accurately, welcome to the **Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game**.

This book is your guide to surviving your crawler's fitful first steps, and it provides rules for both players portraying crawlers fighting (and sometimes failing) to survive and the Game Master (GM) orchestrating the chaos. Other books have more detailed information on different facets of the game:

- *Crawlers & Customization* walks players through creating their own crawlers, as well as details about many of the Skills, Spells, and equipment that will help them survive and maybe even thrive in the dungeon.
- *Game Master's Campaign Toolkit* is all about what a Game Master needs to run the game, including how to use monster Mobs, create engaging Boss Battles, design a Neighborhood, and other guidance for being your crawlers' biggest fan while making them work for every victory.
- *Atlas: Tutorial Floors* features a wealth of setting information and art—perfect for learning about the World Dungeon. Think of it as a neat overview of all the ways this game can go horribly wrong for the crawlers (because it will).
- *Par for the Course* provides a brand-new introductory adventure using Carl, Princess Donut, and team Meadow Lark. *Par for the Course*, along with this book, is designed to get you playing in the World Dungeon quickly, consequences be damned.

If you're confused, don't worry! The System AI anticipated that. The answers are all here in this book—assuming you live long enough to find them.



WELCOME, CRAWLER

Welcome to the First Floor.

With one fateful step, you enter the World Dungeon.

What is the World Dungeon? Oh, you'll find out. For most of you, this will be a confusing plunge into the interface, rules, and jargon of your new existence. All but one of you will enter the World Dungeon as a lowly 1st-level crawler, a poor sap left over from the apocalypse who'll have to fight tooth-and-nail to survive.

One of you will play as the Game Master (GM), that strange, disembodied voice that describes your fate and that led you here in the first place. If you're playing as the GM, you can skim through this section of the manual, or you may want to skip ahead to Being the Game Master (see p. 7) section of this book after you finish this one.

If you're the GM, congratulations! You get to torment your fellow players with all manner of deadly and bizarre nonsense. That's an achievement that keeps on giving.

As for the rest of you?

Hold on to your butts. Shit's about to get weird.

WHAT IS A ROLEPLAYING GAME?

Seriously? You're a *Dungeon Crawler Carl* fan and you don't know what a roleplaying game is? Whether you think you know or not, I'm gonna explain it like you're a silly little baby—which, in the grand scheme of the galaxy, you are.

A roleplaying game is a cooperative social group activity with game rules that use imagination, improvisation, and a random element provided by dice to tell stories. In this game, those stories are set in the world of *Dungeon Crawler Carl* by Matt Dinniman. Rather than play through the events of the novels, the players together decide the details of their characters and serve as the creative designers of their own version of the story.

Throughout the story, one player takes the role of the Game Master (GM) while the other players take the roles of protagonists working together to survive the perils of the World Dungeon. As they play, the GM presents the players with challenges for their crawlers to overcome by exploring the dungeon, socializing with many Non-Player Characters, and wreaking

incredible violence on monster Mobs, Bosses, and even gods (probably best to avoid the latter as long as possible, though).

In many ways, listening to a roleplaying game can feel like listening to an audiobook (and it especially sounds a lot like a LitRPG audiobook). The GM uses spoken descriptions to paint a picture of the environment and the objects and creatures within it. Players may ask clarifying questions and then describe the Actions their characters take, often going beyond just what each Player Character (PC) tries to accomplish, to how they intend to do it, and with what.

The GM and all the players listen to what everyone is saying, so they're aware of the full situation. Of course, unlike a scripted audiobook, the outcome of encounters in an RPG is neither decided by a single person nor is it decided in advance. Instead, a combination of what the rules make possible, what the players decide to attempt, and what results the dice provide creates situations that no one, not even the GM, can anticipate in advance.

TOO MANY "LEVELS"

In the *Dungeon Crawler Carl* novels, the term "level" refers to a crawler character's experience level, Skill level, and dungeon level. In the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game*, we've separated this into different terms to keep things clear:

Level: Character experience level.

Rank: Skill level.

Floor: Refers to the depth of the dungeon. As crawlers descend deeper into the World Dungeon, they move to "lower floors." Higher floors are closer to the surface of the planet. "F" is a common abbreviation for the current Floor Number (F1, F2, F3, etc.).

You'll find a few exceptions related to quoting or referencing the novels.

PLAYING THE GAME

In the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game*, your group shares the narrative of your own World Dungeon, imagining the heroes, Mobs, Bosses, and evil intergalactic corporations all at play. In this game, the Action takes place in your mind and on the game table, and it looks like this:

Joe (as the Game Master): After hours of grinding in this mossy submerged section of the dungeon, your party emerges onto dry land.

Paige (as Brayden): Thank the gods... my wrinkles were starting to get wrinkles. I forgot what it's like to be dry.

Ben (as Kai): I don't think we're out of the woods yet, but we've got—how long have we got until the floor collapses? It's not long.

Koda (as Beatrix): You know you can check your HUD, right?

Andrew (as Isabella): Yeah, but he likes asking you.

Ron (as Park): It doesn't help that Beatrix has been the official party timekeeper since we got to this floor.

Joe: You have 12 hours remaining, so you all need to find a stairwell soon. The dry area you've emerged into is made of dark stone, with statues of Kua-Tin warriors lining a wide passageway that leads to a pair of immense metal doors.

Paige: Hiii Zev!

Ben: Something fishy's going on here. Ron, you want to cover us while we check for traps? Isabella, take the front. Brayden, stay back. We don't have time for you to set off another trap and get turned into a hamster again.

Joe: Ron, there are clear sight lines for Park to cover the team. Andrew, how is Isabella checking for traps?

Andrew: I'm going to check out the statues first. That's Intelligence and Detect Trap to check, right?

Joe: Yep!

Andrew: Ooh, a nice roll. That's an 18 for my total!

Joe: The good news is that you notice the statues start to move just as the watery passage you came through ices over, blocking your way out. You've got one Action before the scene freezes as you hear the notes of the Boss Battle music start to play.

The game continues from there with the GM setting the scene and challenges, the players acting as their protagonists, and the dice helping to tell the story.





CHOOSE YOUR ROLE

To play the ***Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game***, you'll gather with others to tell an exciting story in the ***Dungeon Crawler Carl*** universe. The first step is choosing whether you'll take part as a player representing one of the story's protagonists (taking on roles like Carl or Donut) or the Game Master (GM) who narrates the scene and plays the other characters, ranging from the friendly saferoom Bopcas to the sadistic System AI, which we all know is the *best* role.

Together, your group will come up with the basics of what kind of ***Dungeon Crawler Carl*** story you'd like to tell, what your characters are good at, their internal struggles, how they push the envelope to earn views and fans, and other details.

Or if you're a masochist and have too much time on your hands, you can play with yourself to no end. And no, that wasn't a double-entendre.

BEING A PLAYER

As a player, you take on the role of a single character in the story. To do so, you can:

- **Choose or Create a Character:** You'll either choose one of the iconic characters in the Starter Set Box or create your own (see *Crawlers & Customization*) to play as in the game. You decide the character's Actions, embody them in roleplay, and keep track of your Stats, Skills, Spells, gear, and achievements.
- **Form a Party:** Work together with other players and form your party. A tight team that works together has the best chance for survival, especially on the earlier floors. Your party can be a group who already knows each other, like team Meadow Lark, a group that forms in the dungeon for the sake of protection and/or effectiveness, or a mix, like the Royal Court of Princess Donut.
- **Survive the Dungeon and Find the Stairwells:** In play, you'll face the dungeon together, dealing with Mobs, traps, and Non-Player Characters (NPCs). On each floor, you'll face new challenges and work together to overcome the dungeon or die trying.
- **Level Up and Grow:** As you explore the dungeon, you'll gain character levels, learn new Skills or Rank up the ones you already have, master new Spells, and overcome your traumas and regrets.
- **Build Your Legend:** Push the envelope! Surviving the dungeon isn't just about living through the fights.

You'll need to act recklessly, go overboard, and bend the rules to get views, fans, and, hopefully, sponsors. In other words, YOLO.

BEING THE GAME MASTER

As a Game Master (GM), you fill in the world around and beyond the players' characters. To do so, you:

- **Guide the Story:** The GM is the narrator for the story. You set the scene, from the dungeon to the talk shows and the corporations battling for supremacy in the *Dungeon Crawler World* storyline. When the players act, you decide how the dungeon or galaxy reacts. Ruling the universe takes practice, so you can get started with the *Par for the Course* adventure in this Starter Set.
- **Populate the Dungeon:** In addition to the narration, you'll play all the other characters (NPCs) that the protagonists interact with, including other crawlers played by the GM (called GMCs). NPCs will include merciless Mobs, brutal Bosses, non-hostile characters and allies, elite quest-givers, alien talk show hosts, and the System AI itself.
- **Decide on Rules:** The rules presented in this book cover most situations you and your players will experience in the dungeon. Where there's ambiguity or a question, you determine the ruling to keep the Action moving.
- **Run Floors, Neighborhoods, and Quests:** The *Game Master's Campaign Toolkit* has everything you need to flesh out Tutorial Floors and run interview shows.

DISCUSS BEFORE YOU PLAY

Before you start playing, talk about what topics are cool and what's out of bounds for your group. The *Dungeon Crawler Carl* novels address a lot of heavy subjects that not everyone may want to deal with while playing in the World Dungeon.

This can range from general topics like abandonment issues to specifics like changing spider-like Mobs to another type of monster to accommodate a player with arachnophobia. Setting these boundaries early ensures safe and fun gameplay for everyone. But... please don't remove the spiders if you can help it. They always make crawlers scream the loudest.

RHYTHM OF PLAY

The three main ways the crawlers can engage with the World Dungeon boil down to social interaction, exploration, and combat. Whichever one you're experiencing, the game unfolds according to this basic pattern:

- 1. The Game Master Describes a Scene:** The GM tells the players where their crawlers are and what's around them (how many doors lead out of a room, what's on a table, and so on).
- 2. The Players Describe What Their Crawlers Do:** Typically, the characters stick together as they travel through battlefields and other environments. Sometimes different characters do different Actions: one character might search through files while a second examines a stack of books, and a third keeps watch for enemies. Outside of combat, the GM ensures that every character has a chance to act and decides how to resolve their activity. In combat, the characters take Actions, and dice rolls inform the outcome of their Actions.

In certain situations—particularly combat—the Action is more structured, and everyone takes Actions at different parts of a round. The rest of the time, the characters are free to act in the dungeon environment.

- 3. The GM Narrates the Results of the Crawlers' Actions:** Sometimes resolving a task is easy. If a character walks across a room and tries to open a door, the GM might say the door opens and describe what lies beyond. But the door might be locked, it may have a dastardly trap that goes off when opened, or some other circumstance might make it challenging for a crawler to complete a task.

In those cases, the GM might ask the player to perform a Skill Check to help determine what happens. Describing the results often leads to another decision point, which brings the game back to Step 1.

This pattern holds true during every game session (each time you sit down to play the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game*), whether the crawlers are gathering information from an Elite, infiltrating a Boss's lair, or fighting for their lives against endless waves of Mobs—and yes, sometimes they are literally endless.

In certain situations—particularly combat—the Action is more structured, and everyone takes Actions at different parts of a round. The rest of the time, the characters are free to act in the dungeon environment.

EXCEPTIONS BEAT GENERAL RULES

General rules govern each part of the game. For example, the combat rules tell you that melee attacks use Strength and ranged attacks use Dexterity. That's a general rule, and a general rule remains in effect as long as something in the game doesn't explicitly say otherwise.

The game also includes elements—Skill benefits, Spells, magic items, and the like—that sometimes contradict a general rule. When an exception and a general rule disagree, the exception wins. For example, if a feature says you can use your CHA Mod when using certain Skills, you can do so, even though that statement disagrees with the general rule. Just don't choose a Hobgoblin race and expect your Charisma Stat to help anything at all.

BEFORE STARTING PLAY

The setting of *Dungeon Crawler Carl* is rough, bleak, and full of fucked-up shit (honestly—how many readers have been brought to tears at one point or another?), but it's also a place where weird and hilarious shit happens all the time. To ensure you're creating a story that everyone feels welcome to join in the fun, consider the following and remember that it's the *crawlers* who are supposed to suffer, not the *players*.

PLAYING NICE

Tabletop roleplaying games, including the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game*, are social activities. Just like team sports, family dinners, school projects, or work, sometimes it takes a bit of effort at the table to ensure everyone becomes and stays friends. Many groups don't explicitly make new friends, but without keeping an eye on camaraderie and everyone's limits, game groups can fall apart easily. Even for folks who've read the series and expect the same off-beat humor and tone, they may get tired of quips about killing their mother or illicit asshole money jokes. You can set a novel down, but it's harder to take a break from a game in progress.

More information on considerate play is available in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game Core Rulebook*. Key terms are emphasized here so you can decide which tools are right for you and your group and find more information on them.



COMMUNICATION

While the System AI might be an asshole, that doesn't mean you have to be! If you're the GM, you're probably the leader at the table. It's important to smush any asshole-like behavior. Every player (including you) should feel free to be themselves and tell the kind of story that they want!

The *Dungeon Crawler Carl* novels engage with some heavy themes like violence, oppression, abandonment, constant surveillance, and more. Not everyone wants to deal with all of those themes explicitly during each session, so it's usually helpful to discuss with the group before you start gaming—whether in person or via chat—their experience with *Dungeon Crawler Carl* novels, and set expectations for the game. Players might want to set boundaries (like no spiders, gore related to eyeballs, or spooky babydoll heads). It's important that everyone respects each other's wishes. Remember that this is a cooperative game.

MAKE A PARTY, NOT JUST A CHARACTER

As players, it's your job to make a character that'll work with the group. Unless the table decides otherwise, it's good to assume that neither players nor their crawlers should hate one another, try to get on another's nerves, or act maliciously (stealing from, attacking, or otherwise sabotaging) against other party members. It's no defense to say you're just playing your character when you act this way. Now if the rest of the players all agree that it'll be fun for them if you play that character, then you're all on the same page and it's not an issue.

STARTING A CAMPAIGN

When you start a *Dungeon Crawler Carl* campaign or just play a one-off game, it's worth putting an effort into what'll make everyone enjoy the game. Often folks do this as a group discussion (either a real-time discussion or via chat and email) so they can collectively agree on what the game might involve (including those off-limit topics for people ready to share). This is often part of what's called a *session zero* (or *session 0*).

Other times GMs recruit players with a campaign sheet or flyer describing non-negotiable elements up front so that anyone not interested can pass. At conventions or game store events, you may be limited to a short paragraph, and can quickly establish any ground rules before beginning the story or adventure.

TOOLS

A wide variety of safety tools can help ensure everyone has a safe and fun experience at the game table. They also help groups get onto the same page and are useful to avoid or resolve problems that come up in play. These are often called "RPG safety tools," but you'll also find lots of options if you search for "consent in RPGs" or "considerate play in RPGs."

While these tools are most helpful for new groups, long-term groups and experienced gamers can still find them useful. Check out some or all of the following tools and topics:

- Aftercare for RPGs
- Consent Checklists for RPGs
- Consent in Gaming
- Deck of Player Safety
- Lines and Veils
- The X-Card

DICE

Like most roleplaying games, the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* uses dice to determine the outcomes or consequences of players' Actions. The dice add a random element that can lead the story in different directions, and that unpredictability is what makes gameplay so exciting for the viewers at home.

TYPES OF DICE

The *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* utilizes many types of dice. During gameplay and in rules descriptions and tables, the inclusion of a "d" represents "die" or "dice," which is paired with the number of sides of the die. A "d6" represents a typical six-sided die included in many board games, and a "d20" represents the 20-sided die, which is used for many roleplaying games. Like those, the d20 is the most commonly used die when exploring the World Dungeon.

THE D20

The most common roll players make in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* is the d20, which is used to determine Success or Failure in many cases. The d20 roll is central to gameplay, and players always want to roll high when rolling a d20. But if they roll



D8



D6



D2



D4



D20

low, that's great, too, because then everyone's favorite System AI gets to wreak some havoc.

GMs do not roll the d20 for Mobs and other effects; fate is in the hands of the players and their crawlers.

OTHER DICE

Dice, from the two-sided die (d2) to the twelve-sided die (d12), are used for a variety of tasks. Players will use many dice to roll for effect, and the most common effect roll is to determine damage in combat. Some dice have additional uses, like the d2, which is often used when helping a fellow crawler succeed at a task.

The value given before the letter "d" indicates if multiple copies of the same die need to be rolled. For example, if a rule says to roll 3d6 to calculate the damage from an attack, that means the player should roll three six-sided dice and add them together for the attack's final damage value.

ROUNDING

Sometimes an effect requires a player to use half or a quarter of a value. In any case where rounding is called for, round down.

At times, a static number is added or subtracted from the die roll, indicated by placing a + or - after the die listing, followed by the static number. For example, 2d8+4 means to roll two eight-sided dice, add them

together, and then add 4. If a die notation has a minus sign after it and then a number, you subtract the number from the result of the die or dice instead.



D12

Who knew when you flunked out of junior high and left your school days behind that real life would require so much math? Don't worry. You'll figure it out... or someone else at the table will.

UNCOMMON DICE



D10

"Luck goes both ways, like your mom." The same logic applies to a d2. The rules may occasionally call for a d2 (a two-sided die). While there are dice marked 1-2, it's also possible to just roll a d6, treating results of 1-3 as a 1 and 4-6 as a 2 if using it as a d2. Or just flip a coin.

If you need d100, and generally only the GM would use this to roll on a table, grab two ten-siders. Roll one for the 10s place, and the other for the 1s place. Some d10s are numbered 0-9 while others are 1-10. If you get a result of 0-0 or 10-10, consider it 100.

VIRTUAL DICE

If you prefer, numerous electronic options can replace the use of physical dice. If you'd rather use virtual table top software, it almost certainly includes a dice-roller option, allowing you to roll any combination of dice and modifiers. Players may also utilize online or app-based dice-rollers and random number generators.

THE FIVE CORE STATS

At the core of every character, Mob, Boss, and NPC are the Five Core Stats. Each one measures a crawler or other character's aptitude in physical or mental categories, including:

- **Strength (STR):** A measure of physical power. It's the backbone for Skills that use brawn and focus on physical combat.
- **Intelligence (INT):** A measure of smarts and knowledge. Not only is Intelligence the basis for Skills

based on wit and wisdom but it also determines the amount of Mana your crawler can access to power Spells (at a 1:1 ratio). Dummies also don't last long in the dungeon. Work smarter, not harder.

- **Constitution (CON):** A measure of toughness and physical gumption. It's the core of Skills centering on stamina, both mental and physical, and it determines your Health. Viewers like crawlers who can take a hit or seventeen, so get tough, and stay tough.
- **Dexterity (DEX):** A measure of agility and coordination. Dexterity is fundamental for Skills that rely on speed and nimbleness, and it enhances your ability to avoid attacks. This isn't a dance competition (yet), but being light on your feet will most certainly come in handy.
- **Charisma (CHA):** A measure of your presence, whether charming or intense. Charisma is at the heart of Skills that influence, cajole, and coerce, and it's necessary to attract viewers of the intergalactic gameshow of *Dungeon Crawler World*. If you can get everyone else to like you, they're less likely to want you dead. Right?

Each of these Stats has a score. That score is a number between 1 and... well, you don't know the upper limit right now. A typical human crawler starts with scores between 3 and 5. If you're using one of the premade crawlers, their Stats are already filled in. To learn more about creating your own crawler, see *Crawlers & Customization*.

These scores can be used for direct comparison to gauge capability. A Stat's potency also determines the modifier that is added to d20 tests.

TABLE 1: STAT MODS

STAT VALUE	STAT MODIFIER
1–2	+1
3–5	+2
6–9	+3
10–19	+4
20–49	+5
50–99	+6
100–149	+7
150–199	+8
200–299	+9
300+	+10

STATS AND MODS

When referring to Stats, if the text refers to the full name, such as Intelligence, it refers to the score. When it refers to the abbreviation, such as INT, it refers to the modifier value. Generally, the scores are used for comparison or some derived values—like a crawler's Strength score is used to determine what they can lift—while the modifier values apply to most gameplay Actions and rolls.

UNENHANCED & ENHANCED STATS

Stats are divided into two layers. A crawler's base layer, called Unenhanced, includes their Stats when they walk into the World Dungeon, plus Stat potions and transformations like the type Princess Donut and Prepotente experienced. As crawlers gain new Stat Points from leveling up (see *Advancement in Crawlers & Customization*, p. 42), these improve the Unenhanced Stat layer.

The second layer of Stats, called Enhanced, includes the Unenhanced score plus any bonuses from gear, Spells, Buffs, and other sources. If you want to thrive in the dungeon, you've got to pay attention to both layers. Then add some frosting, some candles, and voilà! Crawler Cake.

SKILLS

In addition to Stats, crawlers also possess a variety of Skills. These Skills represent specific ways that knowledge, training, experience, and other factors combine to augment crawlers' Stats.

The variety of Skills in the game are filtered into the following categories:

- **Attack Skills:** These Skills represent aptitude with weapons, techniques, tactics, and other abilities to help a crawler survive against the odds of the World Dungeon's denizens and monster Mobs.
- **Spell Skills:** These Skills show a crawler's ability to warp reality, shaping their available Mana into a variety of effects. Many are used in combat, while others are used in exploration or social settings.
- **Utility Skills:** These Skills help crawlers navigate the dungeon, influence NPCs, craft items, and perform other useful Actions outside of combat. They're rarely helpful in direct combat and are more effective when exploring the dungeon or interacting with NPCs and other crawlers.

- **Passive Skills:** Some Skills in the above categories are marked as Passive. Passive Skills don't require Skill Checks to activate, but they also advance more slowly than other Skills.

Each Skill ranges from 0 to 20, though training up a Skill past 15 requires particularly impressive attention to and training of the Skill (yeah... good luck with that). Learn more about increasing a crawler's Skill Ranks in *Crawlers & Customization*, p. 20.

Ready-to-play crawlers already have their Skills applied. To see all the Skills available to crawlers on the Tutorial Floors, refer to *Crawlers & Customization*, starting on page 20. In addition, players can create their own Skills (see *Crawlers & Customization*, p. 20).

THE CORE MECHANIC

Whenever interesting (or dangerous) possibilities emerge when a crawler attempts to affect their current predicament, the crawler's player makes a Check. For each Check:

1. **Determine the Challenge:** The players and GM discuss the challenge at hand and the cost of Failure, setting the situation so all players know what's at stake.
2. **Determine the Approach—Stats & Skills:** With the challenge in mind, each player determines their approach to the challenge narratively, which then determines how the rules support that plan. In some cases, a crawler will have the appropriate Skill, which determines which Stat Mod applies to the effort as well.

In other cases, it may be most helpful to think about which of the Five Core Stats the challenge applies to, then determine which Skill (if any) is the best way to apply that Stat to the situation. In other cases, a Stat alone may be the best way to check whether the crawlers succeed or fail.

Once Stats and Skills are decided, apply the Stat Mod and the Skill Ranks; these modify the player's d20 roll in their attempt to overcome the challenge.

3. **Apply Benefits and Penalties:** In addition to the crawler's Stats and Skills, a variety of effects can occur, ranging from lighting and situational benefits bestowed on a crawler (called Buffs) to darkness and situational penalties that affect a crawler (called Debuffs). The most common benefit is a catch-all called Advantage, while the most common penalty is called Disadvantage.

4. **Roll the d20:** Once Stats, Skills, and any benefits or penalties are determined, the player rolls the d20 and adds the die roll result to the total from Steps 1 through 3.
5. **Compare the Total to the Difficulty:** If the total of the Check meets or beats the value of the Difficulty determined by the GM, the crawler succeeds. If the total is less, they fail.
6. **Determine Degrees of Success or Failure:** In addition to Success or Failure, a crawler can succeed with additional positive effects or fail with lingering consequences.

CHECKS WITHOUT SKILL RANKS

When determining the approach, a player can attempt an Attack or Utility Skill Check without their crawler having training in that Skill, but they must roll with Disadvantage, rolling 2d20s (see *Advantage & Disadvantage* below). Use the lower result, and add the appropriate Stat Mod as usual, but no Ranks, as you don't have any.

When you make an untrained Skill Check on the Tutorial Floors (1–2), write that Skill down in the Notes section of your character sheet. At the end of a 2-hour session, gain 1 Rank in one Skill you attempted untrained during that session. Then erase the Skills you wrote down. You cannot "save" them to be gained during subsequent sessions.

A crawler can't attempt a Spell Skill without Ranks in the Spell (unless it's a scroll). Similarly, a Skill designated as "Passive" doesn't require a Skill Check to be made and cannot be attempted untrained, nor does a Passive Skill receive advancement marks through normal use. Such Skills must be gained via magical means or on the Third Floor via a race or class selection, but keep in mind, there are drawbacks to choosing certain races and classes—looking at you, Hobgoblins.

STAT CHECKS

Some Checks rely on the pure power of the Stat without the finesse of a Skill added. These are called Stat Checks and operate identically to the above, except that they skip Step 2. Some examples of Stat Checks and sample Difficulties include:

- **Strength:** To force open a stuck door.
Difficulty 10 + Floor Number



- **Intelligence:** To recognize an illusion.
Difficulty 10 + Rank of the illusion Spell
- **Constitution:** To avoid the effects of alcohol.
Difficulty 10 + Floor Number
- **Dexterity:** To swing on a chandelier.
Difficulty 10 + Floor Number
- **Charisma:** To avoid being beguiled or charmed.
Difficulty 10 + the CHA of the perv trying to manipulate you

Stat Checks can also be used for normal tasks done under pressure, where Failure has consequences... glorious, glorious consequences. Other crawlers cannot aid you with Stat Checks.

DETERMINING THE DIFFICULTY

The GM sets the Difficulty based on how hard something is to do Successfully. The Difficulty is the number the crawler must meet or exceed with their d20 roll, plus all modifiers and Buffs, to be Successful in the Check.

The Difficulty starts at a base of 10, modified by the number of the floor the crawler is on—the dungeon wants the crawlers challenged—then modified based on whether it is Opposed or Unopposed. These tests are used for all Skill Checks since the GM doesn't roll d20s against the crawlers.

Always determine if the Check is Opposed or Unopposed before the crawler makes the Check. While the examples below are guidelines, the GM may simply assign a Difficulty of their choosing if that makes more sense than the formulas that follow.

Okay, more math stuff coming up. If this is too tough, maybe ask your parents to help you with your homework.

OPPOSED CHECKS

An Opposed Check is one where someone or something is standing in the crawler's way (like a Mob, a Boss, another crawler, or your old manager and his damned TPS reports):

$$10 + \text{antagonist's relevant Stat Mod} + \text{Floor Number}$$

The Stat Mod value could be replaced by a Spell Rank, a size class, or whatever force the crawler is up against. Remember that the GM does not roll to "oppose" the crawler's rolls. GMs don't roll d20 Checks. Examples of Opposed Checks include social Checks to influence NPCs and combat, where a crawler's Skill is directly opposed by an antagonist.

UNOPPOSED CHECKS

An Unopposed Check is one that isn't directly against an antagonist and is instead based on how deep the crawler is in the World Dungeon:

$$10 + [\text{Floor Number} \times 2]$$

Examples of Unopposed Checks include Climbing, Dumpster-Diving, Endurance, and most other Skills used to survive the World Dungeon. If the crawler isn't messing around with anyone when making these Skill Checks, it's considered Unopposed.

STAT CHECKS

A Stat Check is when a crawler relies only on their Stats to resist an effect from the environment or from Mobs. As crawlers don't add their Skill Ranks to these Checks, the Difficulty is lower and calculated as:

$$10 + \text{Floor}$$

See? Math isn't *that* hard.

PARTY SKILL CHECKS

Sometimes the whole party has to work together on a single Action, like sneaking past a Gnoll guard post, or climbing down a cliff together, or providing talk therapy to a depressed NPC who's holding the detonator to a bomb rigged to blow up the entire Neighborhood.

In such cases, every player rolls a Skill Check for their crawler and compares it to the Difficulty. If half or more of the party succeeds on their individual Skill Checks, the party succeeds. The crawlers can't aid each other since they're all performing the Skill together.

In a Party Skill Check, an Amazing Success or better turns one party member's failed check to a Success, while a Major Fail or worse turns another party member's Success into a Failure. See *Degrees of Success and Failure* on the next page.

ESCALATING CHECKS

Some Difficulties aren't a single number, but rather multiple escalating values. It means the lower Difficulties provide lesser results, while higher Difficulties provide better results.

This often occurs when collecting information or making other low-stakes Checks. It allows multiple crawlers to succeed, each providing a different tidbit of information. The highest roll gets the best result, but everyone who rolled a Success usually gets something—much better than giving all of the information to the one guy who rolled a Crit.

When a single crawler makes an escalating Check, they use the best result they achieved and all warranted results with a lesser Difficulty.

ADVANTAGE & DISADVANTAGE

When a rule instructs a player to roll with Advantage or Disadvantage, it's always telling them what to do when they roll the d20 as part of a Check. When a character has Advantage, the player rolls an extra d20 and keeps the best (highest) result. When a character has Disadvantage, the player rolls an extra d20 and keeps the worst (lowest) result.

If a character ever has both Advantage and Disadvantage, they cancel each other out, and the player rolls normally.

In a similar way, two instances of Advantage or Disadvantage don't combine: The player still only rolls one extra die. If you have two reasons to roll with Advantage and one for Disadvantage, one Advantage cancels out the Disadvantage, leaving you with Advantage.

MOB ADVANTAGE & DISADVANTAGE

When the GM's Mobs gain Advantage or suffer Disadvantage, it works differently since the GM doesn't roll the d20 (yes, we're going to keep reminding you of this).

When a Mob has Advantage, add 5 to the Difficulty of the Mob's Action, Evade, or other relevant quality. When a Mob has Disadvantage, the Difficulty of the Mob's Action, Evade, or other relevant quality is reduced by 5.

In the case of an Attack Action, the targeted crawler(s) gain a free Evade Check against the Disadvantaged attack. If they fail that free Evade Check, the crawler may spend an Action to Evade and roll the Check again (and roll against additional attacks as usual).



DEGREES OF SUCCESS AND FAILURE

“Success is admirable. Failure is memorable.”

Determining Success is simple: Compare the crawler’s final roll result to the Difficulty. If the result meets or exceeds the Difficulty, they succeed. If it doesn’t, they fail.

Of course, viewers across the galaxy aren’t tuning in for routine Success. They want daring moves, big risks, and spectacular outcomes—the messier, the better. Failure is often where real drama happens. The audience loves to see crawlers pushed to their limits, betting on who will fall and who will somehow survive against the odds.

When making a Check of any kind, your total result matters, though in many situations, extra Success or Failure simply adds flavor. The GM then determines how much your total result beat, or failed to beat, the Difficulty of the Check. The GM should announce the degree of Success or Failure, but not the exact amount they succeeded or failed by, except for a “Near Miss” result.

The following sections outline the different degrees of Success and Failure based on how much the crawler’s roll beat or missed the Difficulty of the task. A result that is equal to the Difficulty is a “Success by 0”—tie goes to the runner, and all that. Critical Hits and Critical Fails do not also trigger the results of a Success or Failure by 10 or more; the crawler benefits from the single highest degree of Success or Failure.

Degrees of Success and Failure have additional mechanics in combat. See *Combat*, p. 30.

SUCCESS

Meeting or beating the Difficulty is a Success. It generally indicates progress toward a goal.

- **Natural 20 (Critical Hit):** On a roll of a Natural 20 (a 20 on the die without any modifiers), the best possible result occurs, and the crawler performs the Action perfectly.
- **Success by 10 or more (Amazing Success):** The crawler’s Action has more impact than normal, such as accomplishing the task more quickly, impressing nearby NPCs, using less material, or a similar effect.
- **Success by 0–9 (Standard Success):** This is the most basic Successful result.

FAILURE

A result under the Difficulty or target number is a Failure. The GM ultimately decides what happens, based on the degree of Failure and the current situation.

- **Fail by 1–2 (Near Miss Fail):** So close, but still a fail.
- **Fail by 3–9 (Standard Fail):** A normal Failure. To keep the game moving, the GM may allow a crawler to fail forward, also known as succeeding with a consequence.
- **Fail by 10 or more (Major Fail):** A Failure to this degree comes with some manner of consequence, such as breaking a common tool, the crawler embarrassing themselves, or spending too much time as the clock ticks closer to floor collapse.
- **Natural 1 (Critical Fail):** On a roll of a Natural 1 (a 1 on the die without any modifiers), the crawler achieves a Failure so abysmal that viewers will talk about on the next recap episode. This Failure is the worst possible outcome, and consequences might include pummeling an ally instead of an enemy, breaking a weapon or an important tool, or gaining a Debuff. Also, you should be ashamed of yourself.

CHECKING AGAIN

For some Actions outside of combat, it may make sense to just try again. In cases when that’s an option, consider skipping the Skill Check roll entirely unless there’s an interesting consequence to the additional attempts. Trying something over and over again isn’t exciting in play or for the recap show.

When a crawler achieves a Major or Critical Fail, they cannot try to test the Skill again in that scene.

FAILING FORWARD

Sometimes your players don’t roll well when the story needs them to. A failed die roll shouldn’t be a roadblock that prevents the story from moving forward.

If there are other avenues for Success (talk your way past the guard, fight your way past, sneak past...), it isn’t an issue. If there aren’t other options, consider failing forward: a Failure on the dice doesn’t mean Failure *per se*, but complications or heavy consequences accompany the Success.

You've heard of "out of the frying pan and into the fire," right? That's failing forward. Some consequences of a bad die roll that aren't utter Failure include:

- A trail that others can follow
- An item is used or used up
- Discovery by a Mob or other adversary
- Loss of AI Favor
- Loss of Health
- Lost time

AI FAVOR

Crawlers are the stars of the show, and without them, viewers across the galaxy couldn't follow their doomed exploits. Crawlers have incredible luck that helps them push past the limits of what's possible, sometimes with the System AI thumbing the scale to help generate incredible results that make excellent TV. After all, if the AI is having a good time, so are the viewers. Probably.

Crawlers earn AI Favor by doing things that are heroic, foolish, stick it to the showrunners, or indulge the AI in some way. Players can spend this AI Favor to:

- Once per Check, reroll a d20 roll before the GM announces the result, except in the case of a Natural 1. Rolling a 1 tends to earn unlucky crawlers an appearance on the recap show's highlight reel.
- Once per round, gain an extra non-Attack Action for their crawler in combat.

CHECK EXAMPLE

Rachel's crawler, Keisha, faces a challenging tile puzzle. Solving it should open the sealed door that Rachel suspects will lead to a hidden area.

Rachel: Alright, I've stared at this for a while, and it's not making sense to me. Does Keisha get something out of this with her Skills that I'm missing?

DJ (the GM): That sounds like an Intelligence Check.

THE STAT

Often, a specific Stat is the easiest part to determine after choosing the Action. Here, the GM calls for Intelligence, and Rachel agrees that the Stat fits since Keisha's approaching the puzzle cerebrally.

Rachel: Yeah. Keisha knows there's something hidden here, and she's been looking it over for a while, but she doesn't have the Investigation Skill.

DETERMINING SKILLS

At this point, Rachel could decide to forgo adding a Skill. In this case, she could move forward with a Stat Check since it's a normal task, and the threat of the dungeon timer counting down is the only pressure. The GM decided there isn't a specific Skill needed, so there's no risk of Disadvantage for not having the relevant Skill this time.

DJ: There's more than one way to make sense of it. What other Skills does Keisha have that might work?

Rachel: Well, Keisha's got Dumpster Diving, Engineering, and Tracking. I don't think Dumpster Diving applies here. What about Tracking? She could lean close and see which tiles have been touched or moved the most to narrow down which ones to pay attention to. Or Engineering to understand how the puzzle operates?

THE NEGOTIATION

Here, Rachel and the GM discuss whether Keisha's Skills are suitable for this challenge, with Rachel proposing how she could narratively see Keisha solving the problem.

DJ: Unfortunately, it's been ages since anyone moved these tiles, so Tracking is out. I could see Engineering working, though.

Rachel: Excellent! Hey, do the dungeon engineering diagrams that Keisha stole from the Grimlock library apply?

DJ: Hmm, I hadn't thought of that working, but the Grimlocks have modified the dungeon for their own ends. Roll with Advantage.

OTHER BONUSES OR PENALTIES

Now that the applicable Stat and Skill have been chosen, it's up to Rachel and the GM to determine if any bonuses or penalties apply. In this case, Keisha has the right item for the job, so the GM grants her Advantage on the Skill Check.



Rachel: Alright, I rolled a 4 and a 16. With Advantage, I keep the 16, then add 2 for Keisha's INT and 3 for her Rank of 3 in the Engineering Skill for a total of 21.

DJ: Nice job. That's a Success. Alright, Keisha starts looking past the tiles and determines that of the six, three seem to matter. Two are dummy tiles, and one leads to another mechanism entirely—a trap!

DEGREES OF SUCCESS

With a Standard Success, Rachel learns more about the puzzle that Keisha's dealing with. With an Amazing Success or better, the GM might decide that Keisha solves the puzzle.

Conversely, she'd waste precious time with a Failure. With a Major Fail, Keisha might be convinced the trap tile is part of the core mechanism. With a Critical Fail, Keisha might either immediately set off the trap or ruin the mechanism entirely, along with any chance of reaching the secret room.

TIME

Time is one of the greatest pressures on players (along with your parents' sweeping disapproval). At the start of every floor, the System AI sets the amount of time before the floor collapses, wiping out the entire floor and killing crawlers who don't descend to the next floor via a stairwell. In addition to that narrative time pressure, this game makes sure everyone has a chance by dividing time for players and their Actions.

GAME TIME

The *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* breaks time down into narrative segments. Game-specific terms for time include:

- **Actions:** In a structured scene like a combat, each crawler gets two Actions. Their Actions can be split up, allowing crawlers to benefit from teamwork.
- **Rounds:** Similarly, in a structured scene, a round contains all of the Actions—both Mobs and crawlers. Each round lasts for 10 seconds.
- **Scenes:** A scene can either be loose or structured, and it includes all of the Actions taken in an area. In combat, a scene is all the rounds combined and is sometimes called an encounter. Outside of combat, the time spent in a location, such as talking

in a saferoom, or traversing a dangerous swamp, or applying foot-themed Buffs via your Enchanted Pedicure Kit of the Sylph is a scene.

THE DUNGEON FLOOR CLOCK TIME

The crawlers have limited time on each floor to reach the stairwell to the next floor down. If they don't make it, they get crushed into oblivion along with the rest of the floor. Isn't that exciting?

While the players and GM don't need to track time exactly or down to the minute, it's generally important to keep track of hours and days. Get a sense of how long the players want to spend on a floor, and have time either fly or stagnate to conform to that. The amount of time until floor collapse is announced at the beginning of each floor, and every crawler has access to the timer.

The GM can customize the time per floor, but generally, the First Floor lasts five days, and the Second Floor lasts six days. Unlike real-life time, each day in the dungeon is 30 hours.

COOLDOWNS

Time also factors into some of the abilities crawlers possess. Some Skills and magic items have cooldown periods which limit how often they can be used. Below are some examples of these timers.

- **Once per round:** You may not spend both of your Actions during a round doing this.
- **Once per scene:** Once during a fight or bar visit.
- **Once per X hours:** One and five hours are the most common. One hour is similar to meandering through a town. Five hours is clearing a Neighborhood of Mobs.
- **Once per day:** Once per 30-hour dungeon day.
- **Once per X days:** Once per X 30-hour days, but resets when transitioning to a new floor.
- **Once per floor:** Once per floor, which resets upon entering a new floor.



ACTIONS

When a crawler does something other than talking, they take an Action. Outside of combat, crawlers can take Actions in any order they like, with each one's result narrated by the GM.

In combat or another structured scene, each crawler gets to take two Actions each round. The crawlers can work together, taking their Actions in any order, to achieve their goals. The Mobs act first unless the crawlers surprise them. Some Actions, marked as an Interrupt, have special uses in a combat scene. More information on Interrupts and phases can be found in the Combat section later in this chapter.

Each player should use tokens, coins, playing cards, or M&Ms to keep track of the number of Actions they have. They should display this for all players, but especially the GM, to see. It speeds up combat greatly when everyone can see who has Actions remaining. This Starter Set includes a set of tokens you can use



just for this purpose, but you can also use them to track other things as needed.

Each time a crawler takes an Action, they can take a Step, which, by default, is up to 10 feet of movement. For a list of Actions players can take for their crawlers, see Table 2 (p. 19).

In addition to these basic Actions, players can gain new Actions from Skills, items, and other sources. Details on Combat-Specific Actions can be found on p. 34.

NO HOLDING ACTIONS OR WAITING

Players can wait to use their Actions until after another crawler acts, but otherwise, players can't hold an Action or prepare for the next round. Combat is quick, and crawlers must make snap decisions—and if they screw up, that just makes it more fun.



TABLE 2: ACTIONS

ACTION NAME	SUMMARY
Make a Check	Make a Skill Check or Stat Check to do what you want to do in the scene.
Cast a Spell	Choose a Spell or scroll in your Hotlist, and roll a Spell Skill Check if it's an Attack. If it's a non-scroll Spell, spend Mana to cast it.
Move	Move up to your crawler's Move value (default 20 feet).
Help	Aid another crawler with their non-combat Skill Check, adding a 1d2 (without Skill Ranks) or 1d6 (with Skill Ranks) before the roll.
Use a Hotlist Item	Use a prepared consumable item or ready another Hotlist Item. To learn more about a crawler's Hotlist, see p. 48.
Retrieve	Move an item from a crawler's Inventory to their Hotlist or hand.

TABLE 3: COMBAT-SPECIFIC ACTIONS

ACTION NAME	SUMMARY
Attack	Use a Skill, Spell, or other effect that requires an Attack Skill Check against a target, rolling damage if Successful. Drawing or swapping a weapon from a Hotlist is free as part of that Action.
Call a Play	Plan an Action, giving an ally a bonus when they perform it.
Catcher (Interrupt)	Take a hit for an ally.
Evade (Interrupt)	Attempt to avoid attacks against your crawler this round.
Heal (Interrupt)	Use a Spell or item to heal. Can also be used as a non-Interrupt Action inside or outside of combat.
Intervene (Interrupt)	Help another crawler with their Skill Check, adding 1d6 after they roll.
Look for Clues	In a Boss encounter, gain information about a foe or environment.
Taunt (Interrupt)	Protect an ally by redirecting a Mob's attacks to yourself.

SOCIAL INTERACTION

While exploring the World Dungeon and venturing outside of it, crawlers will meet and talk to many characters. These opportunities for social interaction can range from haggling with an NPC merchant to insulting the Maestro on his own program to gain fans.

Social interaction primarily takes place through roleplaying and Skill Checks.

ROLEPLAYING

Roleplaying means embodying a character, and it's a big part of everything players do in this game. Players roleplay by deciding how their character sees the world, the Actions they take, and how they talk. GMs do the same for all of the other characters and Mobs.

When a player or GM roleplays, they can take either an active or a narrative approach. No approach is

wrong, and each player should go with what they're comfortable with, including mixing their approaches.

- **Active Approach:** Sometimes called "doing the voices," the Active Approach involves saying exactly what a character says and potentially acting out some of their mannerisms. It's like being back in your high school theater class—you know, the one you had to take to fulfill your fine arts credit sophomore year.
- **Narrative Approach:** A narrative approach involves describing what a character says and does. This one's more like your creative writing elective from junior year—you're telling the story and interacting while using descriptive language.

During roleplaying, it's important for players and the GM alike to pay attention to more than the words; Actions, tone, and attitude also play a part. All of these elements combine to tell the story and can give clues on how to influence that particular crawler or NPC.



USING SKILLS

In addition to saying or describing what a character says, Skill Checks can prove key to social interactions. Utility Skills like Deception, Detect Lies, Intimidate, Negotiation, and Persuasion are often used in addition to roleplaying to determine whether a crawler's speech does the job eloquently or if they're bumbling unintelligible nonsense.

Some players and GMs prefer to make their Skill Check before they roll to determine how well their words come across, while others prefer to roll the Skill Check after. As with approaches, both styles are valid.

Players should keep their Charisma Stat and Skills in mind as they roleplay their crawler, since they may need to make a Skill Check to back up their approach. While a player may be a smooth talker in real life, their crawler may say it in the most awkward or forgettable way without the requisite Skills to back it up, and the inverse can be equally true.

GAINING FANS

After the First Floor, viewers across the galaxy can tune into *Dungeon Crawler World* to watch live feeds showing crawlers' exploits, adventures, and gruesome deaths. Crawlers who want to survive learn quickly to stand out to gain fans. The Second Floor is the perfect opportunity to start on the path to becoming a fan favorite.

On lower floors, cultivating a large fan base can lead to lucrative sponsorships that yield incredible rewards. It can also open opportunities to appear on talk shows and other programs, where crawlers can learn more about the dungeon and the galaxy and make important friends and foes.

SOCIAL PLAY EXAMPLE

In this example, the crawler party finds a curious saloon and tries to gain information.

Joe (the GM): No desert town in the middle of nowhere is complete without an old-timey saloon with swing doors. Within, the air is thick with herbal smoke, like tobacco and gas station incense. Light coming in from the windows and lanterns brightly light the area.



A couple of human crawlers sit at the bar, where a shitfaced Sphinx Cat-folk bartender is drinking at least one shot for every one he pours.

There are about half a dozen tables. Three gamblers sit at one, playing what looks like Mahjong, with small stakes and piles of gold coins on the table. A mysterious hooded stranger sits at a corner booth. And there's a lone Goblin with a blue mohawk sitting at another table who smiles when he sees your group enter.

Ron (playing Park): Park heads right for the other crawlers.

Ben (playing Kai): Kai goes with him.

ROLEPLAYING MOTIVATIONS

In Park's backstory, he got separated from his army unit when the dungeon began, and he hopes that every crawler the party runs into is part of his unit. Giving crawlers backstory and motivations that guide their Actions makes them feel like real people.

Paige (playing Brayden): Bray's headed over to talk to the Goblin. Andrew, do you want to come with?

Andrew (playing Isabella): Sure.

Koda (playing Beatrix): And I actually have Ranks in Mahjong from playing it with Beatrix's host family.

SPLITTING THE PARTY

In situations where there doesn't seem to be much danger, splitting the party is a great way to accomplish multiple goals and give each player or player group small scenes where they're the center of attention.

Joe: Alright, let's do Beatrix first. How does it go?

Koda: Beatrix smiles, glad to find something that reminds her of her normal life before the dungeon. She saunters over to the table, pulling out some gold coins. "Howdy, pardners. You got room for one more? I got plenty of coin to lose." And with that, she jingle-jangles her coins.

ACTIVE ROLEPLAYING

In this case, Koda's saying what Beatrix would say to the gamblers—acting out his character as much as he can.

Joe: The gamblers eye Beatrix suspiciously until they see that gold. After a quick glance at one another, the oldest gambler, a human with a long white beard and dirty clothes that make him look like a prospector, nods. "By all means, join us, little lady." They quickly settle out that hand and start a new game to deal you in. Are you looking to learn something, get rich, or just play?

Koda: After all the fights we've been to, Beatrix just needs some downtime and to play. I'll let the others worry about getting information.

Joe: Sounds good. Let's make a quick Check to see how Beatrix does before we shift the scene elsewhere. If you fail, you'll lose some gold.

Koda: Sure. I've got the Mahjong Skill and since this is a friendly game for Beatrix, how about Charisma?

Joe: I could see that or Intelligence working. It's an Opposed Check against the best player. Roll when ready.

Koda: 13 on the die, plus 4 for Beatrix's CHA and 2 for my Mahjong Ranks, for a total of 19.

Joe: You play well, picking up 8 gold while you play—enough to do well without leaving these gamblers thinking that you're cheating or hustling them. Alright, Paige and Andrew, you get closer and see the Goblin's gap-toothed grin grow.

He's wearing leather armor with rubber reinforcements and spray-painted symbols all over, like he just stepped out of a *Mad Max* movie. He speaks with a loud, nasally voice, "Come, friends. Boblin is ready to be your guide to untold treasures—if you can afford Boblin's mercenary contract! We can get *rich* together."

Paige: Brayden's immediately interested. He lays on his boyish charm. "Wow, we sure are lucky to have run into you, Boblin. Our party's having a rough go of it lately, and with a mercenary like you, we can turn all our luck around."

Andrew: Isabella eyes Boblin suspiciously. Also, Boblin the Goblin? For real?

Ben: The dungeon's been pulling from Earth culture for decades. Let's just roll with it.

EMBRACE OUTSIDE REFERENCES

Media references are part of what makes the setting of *Dungeon Crawler Carl* so fun—and so tragic—by reminding the characters of the world they've lost.

Andrew: Isabella's going to size up Boblin and ask questions. She's trying to figure out if he's bullshitting us.

Joe: Let's see Isabella's Detect Lies Skill Check, then. It's a CHA-Opposed Skill Check, and if you fail, you fall hook, line, and sinker for Boblin's story.

Andrew: Alright. Paige, is Brayden helping?

Paige: Nope, Brayden was willing to spend all his gold to hire Boblin as soon as we sat down. Oooh, he could be Bray's sidekick!

Andrew: I don't know why I expected otherwise. Okay, 8 on the d20, 2 Detect Lies and 2 INT for 12.

Joe: Unfortunately, Isabella doesn't find anything that sounds suspicious about Boblin.

Andrew: I still don't trust him.

Paige: That's okay, I'll trust him enough for the two of us. "Hey, little buddy, what's the going rate for a Skilled mercenary like you?"

Joe: Boblin leans back, thinking for a moment. "For a nice guy like you, only 120 gold."

Andrew: *A hundred and twenty?*

Paige: Gotta spend money to make money. Come on, will you lend me like... 110 gold?

Andrew: Absolutely not!

Joe: While you two debate how you'll pay for this, the scene turns to Park and Kai. The bartender's doing that drunken lean, and he pours you both shots of some kind of brown liquor as you approach. The crawlers, a woman and a non-binary-looking folk look you over—you're pretty sure they're scanning you, and both of them immediately get a disgusted look when they focus on Kai.

Ron: Player Killer Skulls will do that to you, buddy. How about you leave me to talk to these two?

DUNGEON INFORMATION

A few sessions ago, Kai killed two crawlers who tried to take out the party, and he's forever marked with Player Killer Skulls (see *Crawler vs. Crawler*, p. 37). While this might play well with lawless types, the stain on his profile means that upstanding crawlers like these are less interested in talking to a killer. The GM crawlers (GMCs) can also glean other information through their HUD (see *Atlas*, p. 6).

Ben: Yeah, okay. Before I do, what do I see on these two in my HUD?

Joe: The crawlers are Jessica L, Level 7 with no race, class, or player skulls; and Niko A, a level-10 who also lacks race, class, and player skulls. They've got the mark of a party leader, though.

Ron: Park'll be fine.

Ben: Kai takes a seat down the way at the bar.

Ron: Alright, with Mr. Buzz-kill gone, Park orders another round for Jessica and Niko. Park's going to lay it on thick. We don't have enough people to take on that Swamp Dragon, and I'm pretty sure there's a stairwell to the Third Floor in its lair. He's going to be as charming as he can, laying his cards out on the table to start, before trying to recruit them.

NARRATIVE ROLEPLAY

Unlike Koda and Paige, Ron prefers to narrate what Park says and does in a general sense. Since he's not saying the exact words, it's helpful for him to describe Park's emotions, attitude, and intent so everyone can get a clear picture of what Park's Actions look like.

Joe: They're still pretty wary of anybody who hangs with a player-killer. How are you going to change their attitude?

Ron: I'm hoping to influence them with the free drink and Park's Persuasion Skill.

Joe: That works. Definitely an INT-Opposed Check, though. And if you fail, it's clear they're going to want to get away from you. You sent Kai away, so you don't have Disadvantage on this Check.

Ron: Makes sense. I still have an AI Favor in case this goes wrong... and I've got a 3 on the die. I'll spend that AI Favor to reroll, and now I've got a 15 plus Park's 3 Ranks of Persuasion and CHA of 3. 21 should be enough to smooth any ruffled feathers.

CHANGING NPC ATTITUDES

At the start of this conversation, Niko and Jessica, two GM Crawlers, were suspicious of Park. With a Successful Skill Check, their attitude becomes friendly, and continued conversations with them will be easier.

Joe: Indeed. Alright, you've turned them around. Now you can start to make allies...



EXPLORING THE ENVIRONMENT

Crawlers spend most of their time in the dungeon exploring the environment as they seek loot, Bosses, saferooms, stairwells, and other opportunities.

VISION AND LIGHT

Most crawlers need light to take in their environment. Fortunately, glowing green lichen along the walls and some other surfaces produce a common light source on the First Floor. The lichen glows orange on the Second Floor. Torches mounted to the walls are a classic and are found in built-up areas. These provide enough light to see and read anything without penalty. There is no nighttime on the Tutorial Floors, as the glowing lichen doesn't sleep.

Torch Spells and physical torches are also a common reward in Bronze Adventurer Boxes, allowing crawlers to carry their own light. Unfortunately, Mobs, Bosses, and player-killer crawlers often use the dark and obfuscation to snuff out unsuspecting crawlers.

- **Bright Light:** Crawlers suffer no penalties in areas of bright light, like near the center of a torch item, Torch Spell, lantern, or other item that provides light.
- **Dim Light:** In areas of dim light, like areas lit solely by the lichen on the walls of the Tutorial Floors or at the edge of a torch's light, are hard to make out details. Crawlers suffer Disadvantage on Investigation, Perception, and other Skill or Stat Checks that rely on vision.
- **Darkness:** Skill and Stat Checks are made with Disadvantage when in darkness, if the lack of light matters. Lifting a sewer grate might be no harder in darkness than in light, for example, but navigating a claustrophobic maze-like structure is a different story. When moving through darkness, crawlers treat the ground as Difficult Terrain (see below).
- **Torches:** A nice bit of fire provides 20 feet of bright light and another 20 feet of dim light past that.

The Torch Spell (*Crawlers & Customization*, p. 40) is also useful for dealing with the dark. For the specifics of other light sources, see *Crawlers & Customization*.

MOVEMENT

On the Tutorial Floors, the amount of distance a crawler can cover with a Move Action is 20 feet. In addition to taking a Move Action, every time a crawler

takes an Action, they can also take a Step, which is up to 10 feet of distance. A crawler who spends both Actions moving can move a total of 60 feet on their turn—now that's a 0 to 60 we can all get behind.

Crawlers can split their move across Actions. For example, a crawler can take the Move Action as their first Action (giving them a 20 feet plus a 10 foot step for 30 feet total), move 25 feet to take their second Action, then move their remaining 15 feet afterward.

Crawlers can move through unoccupied spaces and spaces occupied by their allies. They cannot move through an enemy space.

Standard crawlers move on the ground, tethered by gravity, and must make an effort to climb, leap, or swim.



MARCHING ORDER

Crawlers should establish their general order when moving about the World Dungeon, which makes it easier to determine character position if the group runs into trouble, from traps to Mobs. This general order can change at any time outside of conflict, such as putting a character with the Survival Skill near the front when navigating a perilous environment.

DIFFICULT TERRAIN

No matter how fancy your feet may be, many types of dungeon terrain can slow down crawlers, Mobs, and other creatures. This includes rubble, thick undergrowth, snow, mud, uneven ground, shallow water, and other effects. Movement across difficult terrain costs 1 additional foot of Move for every foot moved.

DROPPING PRONE

Crawlers can hit the deck on their turn without spending an Action or any movement, gaining the Take Down Debuff. Standing up requires 10 feet of Move, which can be the crawler's Step.

PICKING UP ITEMS FROM THE GROUND

If a crawler needs to pick something up off the ground in a combat scene or other stressful event, whether it's a dropped weapon or an important MacGuffin or anything in between, they can spend 10 feet of Move (such as their Step) to pick it up.

FORCED MOVEMENT

In addition to the chosen movement on a crawler's turn, some effects cause forced movement with a distance in feet. The three types of forced movement are:

- **Pull:** Every foot of forced movement must draw the target closer to the source of the effect. The tentacles of a Krakaren monster that pull crawlers toward its mouth are an example of a pull.
- **Push:** Every foot of forced movement must repulse the target farther away from the source of the effect. When a wrestler crawler tosses a held Mob away from them, they're doing a push effect (see *Crawlers & Customization*, p. 24).
- **Slide:** The most versatile form of forced movement, a slide allows the source to move the target in any

direction, including turning or changing directions. A crawler or Mob that uses telekinesis to freely move objects around is an example of a slide.

SPECIAL FORMS OF MOVEMENT

In addition to simply moving across the ground, crawlers may need to climb, crawl, jump, and swim to navigate the environment. You didn't think we'd make getting around *that* easy, did you?

- **Climbing:** When climbing, it costs 1 additional foot of Move for every foot you move (2 extra feet in Difficult Terrain). Climbing may also require an Unopposed Climbing Skill Check to traverse areas with few handholds or sheer surfaces.
- **Crawling:** Crawlers can crawl? Who knew? Crawlers who move while prone do so at a crawl, which costs 1 additional foot of Move for every foot you move (2 extra feet in Difficult Terrain).
- **Jumping:** Crawlers can make an Unopposed Jumping Skill Check to leap over things, clearing a number of feet up to Rank + STR Mod. Jumping still costs Move but doesn't have any additional cost.
- **Swimming:** Swimming costs 1 additional foot of Move for every foot you move (2 extra feet in Difficult Terrain). Crawlers may need to make Unopposed Swimming Skill Checks against a swift current. Submerged crawlers also need to hold their breath; see *Drowning* in the *Harsh Conditions* section below.

When using one of these movements in difficult terrain, calculate your movement as you go. For example, if a crawler takes the Move Action to Swim 10 feet, then gets out of the water to move an additional 10 feet, they have used 30 feet of Move.

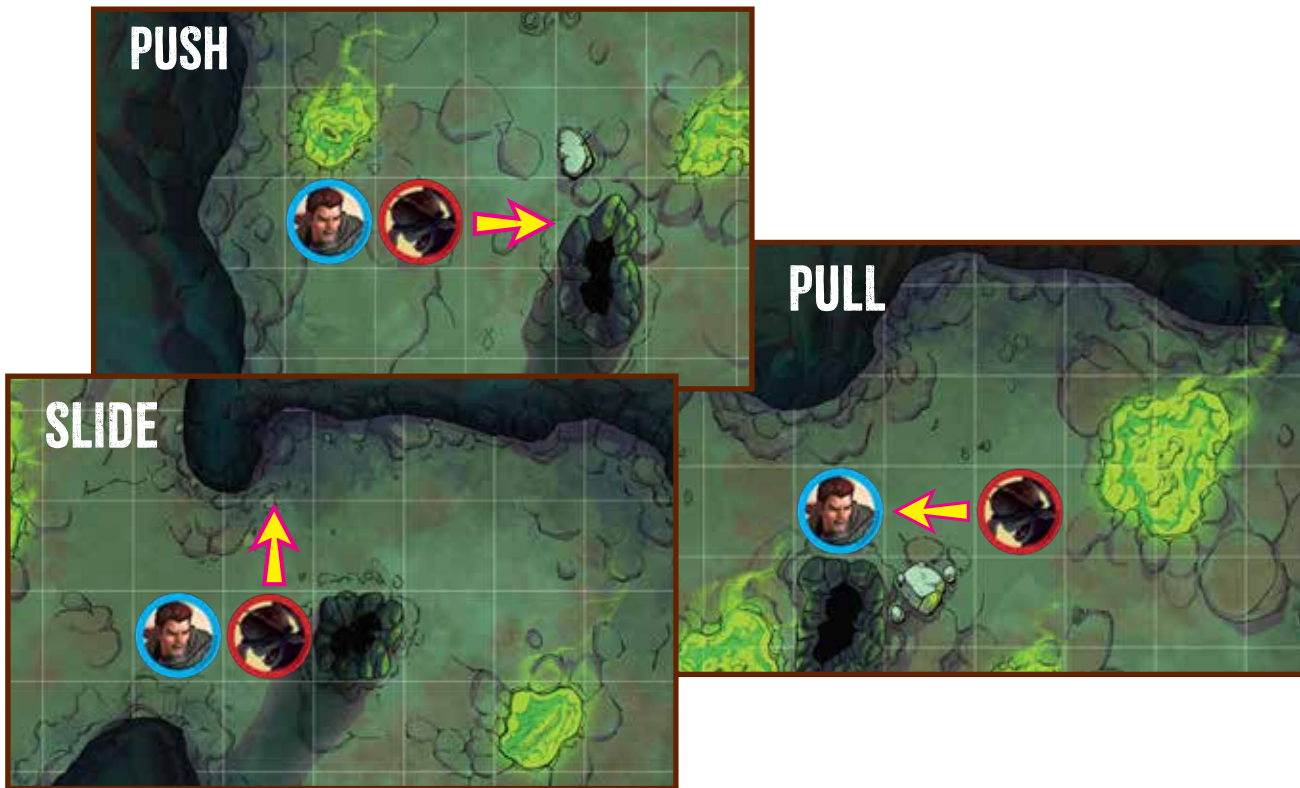
WHY DOES THE GAME USE FEET INSTEAD OF METERS?

Because the AI loves feet. Carl's in particular.

INNATE MOVEMENT TYPES

Creatures in the dungeon may skitter along walls, swim under the surface, or fly over crawlers. Sometimes they even move *through* crawlers, though that rarely ends well for the crawler in question.

Some crawlers gain access to special movement types from magic items, or from their race and class when they reach the Third Floor. Crawlers and creatures with these movement types do not need to make Skill Checks to use them.



- **Climb:** Creatures and crawlers with a climb Move move across vertical surfaces without spending additional Move. That means it costs those Giant Spiders nothing extra to scare the daylights out of you.
- **Fly:** Creatures and crawlers with a fly Move can move through the air. If a flying creature or crawler is knocked unconscious or prone, it falls from the air (see *Falling*, p. 28).
- **Swim:** Creatures and crawlers with a swim Move can move freely through water and similar liquids without spending extra Move. Figuring out how to breathe underwater is another thing altogether.

TRAVEL PACE

In addition to tactically moving through the World Dungeon, crawlers will spend time traveling from one area or Neighborhood to another in their search for a stairwell, to visit locations on a Quest, to meet up with other crawlers, and many other reasons.

Crawlers traveling across the World Dungeon need to determine their marching order (see *Movement* above) and their pace. The crawlers' pace determines how quickly versus how carefully they're moving:

TABLE 4: TRAVEL PACE

PACE	MINUTE	HOUR	DAY
Fast	400 feet	4 miles	38 miles
Normal	300 feet	3 miles	29 miles
Slow	200 feet	2 miles	20 miles

The travel pace has mechanical impacts as well:

- **Fast:** Crawlers moving at a fast pace suffer Disadvantage on their Perception and Survival Skill Checks to notice danger and navigate the dungeon. They also cannot use Hide in Shadows or other efforts to conceal their movement.
- **Normal:** Crawlers moving at a normal pace suffer no benefits or penalties to their Skill Checks.
- **Slow:** Crawlers moving at a slow pace gain Advantage on their Perception and Survival Skill Checks to notice dangers and navigate the dungeon.

Generally, pace to the minute and to the hour are most helpful for overland travel, and a day's travel assumes 10 hours of the 30-hour day spent moving from one place to another. Crawlers can press on past that, but they must make an Unopposed Endurance Skill Check every additional two hours of travel or suffer a level of the Fatigue Debuff.

Vehicles can increase crawlers' travel pace significantly when moving from one part of the dungeon to another, such as making a high-speed exit to the stairwell. More information on vehicles, including statistics, can be found in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game Core Rulebook*.

RACING AND CHASING

Sometimes you need to move fast to resolve a conflict, rather than duke it out. Racing happens when everyone is trying to get to a fixed point. Chasing happens when the goal keeps moving. These contests do not generally use the rules of Party Skill Checks.

RACING

Races (the competitive kind, not the state of being or species of a crawler or Mob) are resolved over a series of Skill Checks called *legs*, which can represent time, obstacles, or several hundred laps around a track. The Skill for the race, or each leg of the race, is usually determined by the type of movement, so Running applies to a foot chase, and a mix of Chopper Pilot and Driving would apply to a vehicle race.

Most races and chases involve three legs, but they can involve as many as the GM wants. Too many might get boring, though. The racers focus all of their energy and Actions on the race itself. Characters with benefits that might allow them to overcome a difficulty can suggest a better Skill at the GM's discretion.

Move Rate Modifier: Each racer adds their Move score divided by 10 (rounded down) as a modifier to all of their racing movement Skill Checks. A crawler with the default 20 Move gets +2, while a racer with 45 Move gets +4. If you're irritated that 20 and 25 both round down, keep in mind the 25 might break a tie later.

NPC Racers: NPCs and Mobs, as usual, don't roll; they instead "roll" a fixed number each round: 10 + Stat Mod + Floor Number + Move Rate Modifier.

Running a Leg: Each racer makes a Skill Check based on the challenge of this leg and adds their Move Mod. Compare results from highest to lowest and assign placement: 1st place to the highest result, 2nd place, 3rd place, and so on. If two or more racers tie, the racer with the higher base Move score wins that placement. Record each racer's placements after every leg.

Winning the Race: After the final leg, add up each racer's placement numbers across all legs. The racer with the lowest total wins. If there is a tie for the lowest total, the racer with the better placement in the final leg wins—a true photo finish. If that's still a tie, it stays a tie.

RACING EXAMPLE

Crawler Adrián, Raul the Crab, and Crawler Tessa race down the beach toward a rookery of baby seals on the Second Floor for some reason. The GM calls it a three-leg race. Adrián has the slowest Move at 20 (Move Mod +2), Raul has 30 (Move Mod +3), and Tessa has 45 (Move Mod +4). Raul is an NPC, so he doesn't roll and automatically gets a 16 (10 + his Dex 1 + Floor 2 + Move Mod 3) each round, but slow and steady can still win the race.

Leg 1: Adrián rolls his Running Skill Check with Move Mod and gets an 18. Tessa gets 12. Raul's automatic result is 16. These totals determine the current placement: Adrián in 1st, Raul in 2nd, and Tessa in 3rd place.

Leg 2: Adrián stumbles with an 8. Tessa gets a 17, and Raul continues with his automatic 16. The second-round placement sees Tessa in 1st, Raul in 2nd, and Adrián in 3rd place.

Leg 3: Adrián gets a 7, but he spends an AI Favor to reroll, and ends up with an 18. Raul gets an ever-reliable 16 again. Finally, Tessa gets a total of 17. Adrián wins the leg, with Tessa closely behind him, and Raul trailing behind them for third.

Now total each placement. Adrián has $1 + 3 + 1 = 5$. Tessa has $3 + 1 + 2 = 6$. Raul has $2 + 2 + 3 = 7$.

Adrián wins with the lowest total, Tessa finishes second, and Raul trails in last place. No ascension for Raul this time.

Vehicles: Some crawlers can access vehicles, which allow them to Move much faster. If you have one of those, Table 5 shows you some samples.

TABLE 5: SAMPLE VEHICLE MOVE RATINGS

VEHICLE	MOVE
Skateboard	30
Bicycle	40
Mid-Sized Sedan	80
Sportscar	100
Motorcycle	120



CHASING

Sometimes you don't want to race someone. Sometimes you want to catch them. Maybe a Battle Baboon just swiped your best weapon. Maybe you *are* the Battle Baboon, and six very angry crawlers are gaining on you. Either way, someone's running, someone's chasing, and the dungeon is absolutely going to make it worse.

A chase works similarly to a race, except the finish line keeps moving, and placement isn't a thing. The GM sets the number of legs based on how far the quarry starts from the chasers, how far the quarry needs to go, and how complicated the terrain is between here and gone-for-good. A straight-up chase through an open area or unobstructed corridor might be three legs. A chase through a bazaar, over a bridge, or through a circus might be five or more.

The quarry isn't going to run in a straight line like an idiot. They're going to knock over fruit stands, barrel through a couple of Goblins carrying a plate-glass window, and slink away at a T-intersection. What Skills are used is up to the GM, but varying the Skills needed to succeed leads to more exciting and dynamic chases. Every leg might use a different one, depending on if you're Running, Jumping, Climbing, or Swimming, but clever crawlers (or quarries) might find a use for navigation-based Skills (like finding short cuts) or even weirder options.

Each leg, every "chaser" makes an Opposed Skill Check, adding in their Move Rate Modifier. The quarry opposes it with the Stat used in the Skill Check (for example, a Running Skill Check is Opposed by the quarry's DEX Mod).

- **Amazing Success or better:** Gain 2 Ground. The GM might instead grant 1 Ground and an alternative bonus, such as allowing you to Intervene for an ally (even though this isn't a traditional combat). You just did something awesome, and the audience loves it.
- **Standard Success:** Gain 1 Ground.
- **Near Miss:** Gain 0 Ground.
- **Standard Fail:** Lose 1 Ground.
- **Major Fail:** Lose 2 Ground. Embarrassing, just like your first-grade teacher always expected.
- **Critical Fail:** You're done. The chase is over for you because you probably ate a wall or ended up neck-deep in something sticky. Eww. You'd better believe we'll see that in tonight's recap episode.

Track your Ground gains and losses as a running total across the legs. If your total hits 4 Ground or

more at any point, you've caught the quarry early. If it hits -4 or worse, the quarry's gone, and you're out of the chase. Everyone else keeps going until the last leg is done or until there's nobody left chasing.

After the final leg, any chaser still in it compares their total. If they have a positive total of 1 to 3, they've caught the quarry. If it's 0 or less, the quarry got away. If the GM wants to determine who catches the quarry first, it's the character with the highest Ground total, using Move as a tiebreaker.

CHASING EXAMPLE

Crawlers Adrian and Tessa alongside their Rat-Kin friend Pisto are trying to steal some drugs from a Bad Llama on the First Floor. The Bad Llama in question screams, flips off the party as best it can, and beats feet. Adrián, Tessa, and Pisto give chase. The GM varies the Opposed Check every leg because the Neighborhood has some flooded corridors, lots of pits, and a straightaway before the Bad Llama can escape into its home turf.

The Bad Llama is an NPC with a Move of 20 (+2 Move Mod), +2 STR and +3 DEX, so its result for each leg is 15 or 16, depending on the leg's Skill. Pisto is also an NPC, but with +1 to STR and DEX, so they get a 14 each leg. Adrián has a Move of 20 (+2), and Tessa has a Move of 45 (+4).

Leg 1 (Swimming): The Bad Llama has a set value of 15. Adrián rolls his Swimming Skill Check and gets a 16. He gains 1 Ground. Tessa gets 10. She loses 1 Ground. Pisto's automatic result is a 14, a Near Miss, so Pisto gains 0 Ground. Totals: Adrián +1, Tessa -1, Pisto 0.

Leg 2 (Jumping): The Bad Llama has a set value of 15 again. Adrián rolls his Jumping Skill Check, gets a 9, and loses 1 Ground. Tessa gets a 26: an Amazing Success. She gains 2 Ground. Pisto continues with a 14. Totals: Adrián 0, Tessa +1, Pisto 0.

Leg 3 (Running): The Bad Llama has a set value of 16 this time. Adrián gets a 17 for his Running Skill Check, and Tessa gets an 18. As usual, Pisto gets 14. Totals: Adrián +1, Tessa +2, Pisto 0.

Adrián and Tessa both end with positive Ground totals, catching the Bad Llama in the end. Pisto did not.

The chaser with the highest positive total at the end gets to the quarry first. In this case, Tessa at +2 reaches the Bad Llama before Adrián at +1. If there's a dispute, the GM decides. A crawler's Move can always be a tiebreaker when needed.

HIDING AND SNEAKING

Crawlers can attempt to hide and sneak past foes while behind cover (see *Combat*) or in dim light or darkness. To do so, they make an Opposed Hide in Shadows Skill Check against nearby foes' Intelligence.

On Success, the crawler gains the Invisible Buff until the crawler comes into view, fails a Hide in Shadows Skill Check, or takes an Attack Action.

HARSH CONDITIONS

Crawlers have more to fear than the Mobs and Bosses of the World Dungeon; there's a million ways to die in the dungeon. (Yes, that was a Seth McFarlane reference).

DROWNING

You can hold your breath for a number of rounds equal to your CON Mod. When you miss a Swimming Check under dangerous circumstances, you might gain the Drowning Debuff, and that's when things get really exciting.

While Drowning, you take 1d6+F damage at the end of each round. Do not take any damage during rounds in which your head is above water. Taking a breath doesn't heal any damage you've already taken, but you can quaff a potion in your Hotlist without physically drinking it.

FALLING

If you have a whoopsie and fall off a ledge or get pushed off the roof of a building, it's gonna hurt. You take 1d6 Bludgeoning damage for every 10 feet you fall, to a maximum of 20d6, and you land prone. When you hit the ground, roll the dice, and hope you're not reduced to a red smear.

HUNGER

While it's rare—and incredibly boring for viewers—for crawlers to starve to death, going without food can kill just as readily as a Mob's bite or claw or third leg. At the end of each 30-hour day that a crawler doesn't eat, they make a Survival Skill Check. If they fail, they lose 3 Health Bar slots (see *Health* in *Combat*) and gain a stackable instance of the Fatigue Debuff. Fatigue levels from this source persist until the crawler eats (or gets eaten).

THIRST

While hunger is a danger, dehydration is a faster killer. For each 30-hour day that a crawler doesn't drink water, they lose 3 Health Bar slots (see *Health* in *Combat*) and gain one stackable instance of the Fatigue Debuff. Fatigue levels from this source persist until the crawler drinks, so glurp, glurp! That's... that's what that means, right?

EXPLORATION EXAMPLE

Here's what play looks like as the crawler party explores a new part of the dungeon.

Joe (the GM): As you turn down the corridor, the environment opens so widely that you can't see the walls on either end of the room. That's partially because the area is filled with mushrooms whose stalks rise 10 to 20 feet high. The caps are similarly wide, and the gills glow a variety of neon colors that dimly light the area. The area smells like fresh dirt, and it's quiet, other than the sounds of your own breathing.

SETTING THE SCENE

Joe sets the scene here by engaging the senses: what the crawlers see, smell, and hear. In addition, he provides the lighting conditions, which are important for both the mood and mechanical effects.

Paige (playing Brayden): And we're sure this is where Niko's party went?

Ron (playing Park): That's what their message said. They were checking out this area before they meeting us back at the saferoom. I don't think we can take that Boss out on our own, and we're running out of time 'til the floor collapses to find other allies. How long have we got?

Koda (playing Beatrix): 9 hours.

Andrew (playing Isabella): Are we sure this is worth it? That's not enough time if we run into trouble here.

Ben (playing Kai): We don't become big damn heroes with sponsorships by playing it safe or leaving our friends behind. Come on, team; we've got this.

Paige: One day, doing what's right instead of what's smart is gonna get us all killed.

Ben: Yeah, but not today. Do we know anything about these mushrooms? Does Isabella want to be the tour guide, as usual?



Andrew: Sure, can I make a Check. Does Survival count?

Joe: I could see Survival working, but since you're thinking about it instead of resisting it, let's go with an Unopposed INT Survival Skill Check. Either Success or Failure, you're going to remember things that you're sure are true.

OFF-STAT CHECKS

The Survival Skill is usually associated with a crawler's CON since it's used to resist hazardous environments. Since Isabella is thinking about the potential dangers, Joe decides the Skill applies but Andrew adds Isabella's INT Stat instead of CON. With each Check, Joe points out the cost of Failure so the players can decide whether they really want to make the Check.

Koda: That's a Difficulty 14 since we're on the Second Floor, right?

Paige: Right.

Andrew: Okay, 10 on the die, 2 for INT, and 3 Ranks of Survival for a 15.

Joe: With that simple Success, you've never experienced mushrooms this big or as bioluminescent. You do know that mushrooms tend to unleash spores so other creatures can spread them around. With mushrooms this big, the spores could be a problem.

Paige: We'd better not breathe those in. Can Brayden and Beatrix take an hour to use our Misc. Junk to make masks?

Koda: That's a great idea!

Joe: Sure, that's pretty simple. Since a protective mask would be Size 2, it would take you 4 hours to craft one in the dungeon. It would give you Advantage on any Checks against any gas or spores. You could also search through your Inventory and decide that some of your Misc. Junk is a medical or painter mask, which would give you +2 on Checks against gas or spores.

CRAFTING IN THE DUNGEON

Most crafting takes place in personal spaces at workbenches, but since those don't exist on the Tutorial Floors, the crawlers will make what they can while in a dangerous area. Due to the mask being Size 2, it takes 4 hours to craft one. See *Crafting in Other Dungeon Activities* (p. 50) for more details.

Paige: Oof, that's a lot of time. Even with Brayden and Beatrix making Fabricate Checks separately, I don't think we have that kind of time.

Andrew: Ron was already against spending one hour, let alone four.

Ron: That's right. Besides, you don't make it onto the recap by spending hours crafting. It's time to act!

Joe: Alright, so what's the plan, crawlers?

PARTY DECISIONS

When the party faces a choice that not everyone agrees with, it's important for the players to decide—and sometimes for their crawlers to discuss in roleplay—as a group. This group prefers to make decisions democratically, so with three deciding that it takes too long, they decide as a group to make the masks out of Misc. Junk.

Koda: I've got to agree with Ron. Four hours is just too much. I'll spend the Misc. Junk as a quick fix.

Paige: Yeah, Brayden has plenty in his Inventory, so I'll do that, too.

Andrew: I'm for it.

Ben: I haven't been tracking Misc. Junk. Can one of our hoarders find one for me?

Koda: Sure, I've got plenty.

Ron: Not me. I'm going to prove to you and the audience that Park's more than tough enough to take on some fungi.

Joe: With your masks in place, you start to head into the mushroom forest. Where are you going?

Andrew: We probably should have figured that out before walking in. I have the Tracking Skill.

Ron: I just got Find Crawler, too. Do we want to start there?

Andrew: Be my guest.

Joe: This is a great time for Find Crawler. Since it's a Passive Skill, you don't need to roll. When you activate it, you see a group of 6 blue dots on your HUD about 600 feet ahead of you, deeper in the forest.

PASSIVE SKILLS

Passive Skills don't require a Skill Check to perform and don't advance like other Skills. Each Passive Skill listing in *Crawlers & Customization* notes how the Skill increases in Rank.

Ron: Alright, let's go.

Joe: Before you start heading in, are you changing your marching order?

Andrew: Since my Survival Skill gave us the information we needed before we walked in, and I have the highest Perception, Isabella will be the lead.

Ben: Kai will be up there with her in case we run into trouble.

Paige: Brayden's in the middle where it's safest.

Ron: And Park is the rear guard.

Koda: Beatrix will be in the middle with Brayden.

MARCHING ORDER

As the party heads into a potentially hazardous environment, determining the Marching Order helps the GM determine who'll be in trouble as unexpected things happen—like Isabella and Kai might be the first ones to walk into a trap, or a ferocious group of Mushroom Maniacs might come up from behind to snack on Park first.

Joe: As you head into the forest, the soft dirt sinks beneath your feet. Isabella's bare feet feel the squish of the moist dirt and the worms wriggling around under her. You get around 30 feet into the alien landscape when an especially brightly-gilled mushroom starts to twist and shudder before launching fuzzy dime-sized spores into the air. The spores conceal the area around you like fog, and I'd like everyone to make a CON Stat Check to resist breathing them in. With Advantage if you have one of the working masks.

Paige: I rolled a 2 and an 11. With Advantage, I keep the 11 and add +1 for CON, which makes it a total of 12 for Brayden.

Koda: I rolled a 5 and 2. So and with the 5 and +2 CON for Beatrix, I've got a total of 7. So much for that mask.

Ben: Kai's got a pair of 19s for a total of 24.

Andrew: 16 for Isabella.

Ron: And I've got a 4.

STAT CHECKS

Since this roll is to resist an effect, no Skill applies, and the crawlers only add their Stat Mod to their total. Stat Checks generally have a lower Difficulty than Skill Checks—see *Stat Checks* in *Determining the Difficulty* (p. 14).

Joe: Brayden, Kai, and Isabella resist the poisonous spores' effect. Park and Beatrix start coughing violently; you both have the Poisoned and Woozy Debuffs until cured. And you're going to have to wait to treat that because you hear things scurrying above you. Mushroom crowns bounce with the weight of the creatures heading toward you, drawn to the spore release.

Ron: I bet we're about to find out what got Niko's team!

COMBAT

One of the most common activities crawlers engage in is combat, as nearly every other living thing (and many unliving things) in the dungeon is constantly trying to kill them. Combat is one of the most structured parts of the game to ensure every player has their opportunity in the spotlight and for their crawlers to survive.

DEGREES OF SUCCESS IN COMBAT

In combat, the degrees of Success have additional mechanical significance for Attack Skill Checks (see *Attacks*, Step 4) and Evade Checks (see the *Evade Action*, Step 2).

SUCCESS

Meeting or beating the Difficulty is a Success. It generally indicates progress toward a goal.

Natural 20 (Critical Hit): On a roll of a Natural 20 (a 20 on the die without any modifiers), the player rolls twice as many base damage dice and then adds their crawler's Stat Mod and other Buffs to the damage. If an effect multiplies the "total damage," that includes the results from the extra Critical Hit dice.

If the crawler achieves a Natural 20 on an Evade Check, they gain Advantage on their next Attack Skill Check against that Mob. And it's probably good for their self-esteem, too.



Success by 10 or more (Amazing Success): The crawler's attack deals extra damage equal to their current Floor Number.

If the crawler achieves an Amazing Success on an Evade Check, they also gain Advantage on their Attack Skill Check against that Mob.

Success by 0–9 (Standard Success): This is the most basic Successful result. For attack Skills, a standard Success means the crawler hits and rolls damage.

FAILURE

A result under the Difficulty or target number is a Failure. The GM ultimately decides what happens, based on the degree of Failure and the current situation.

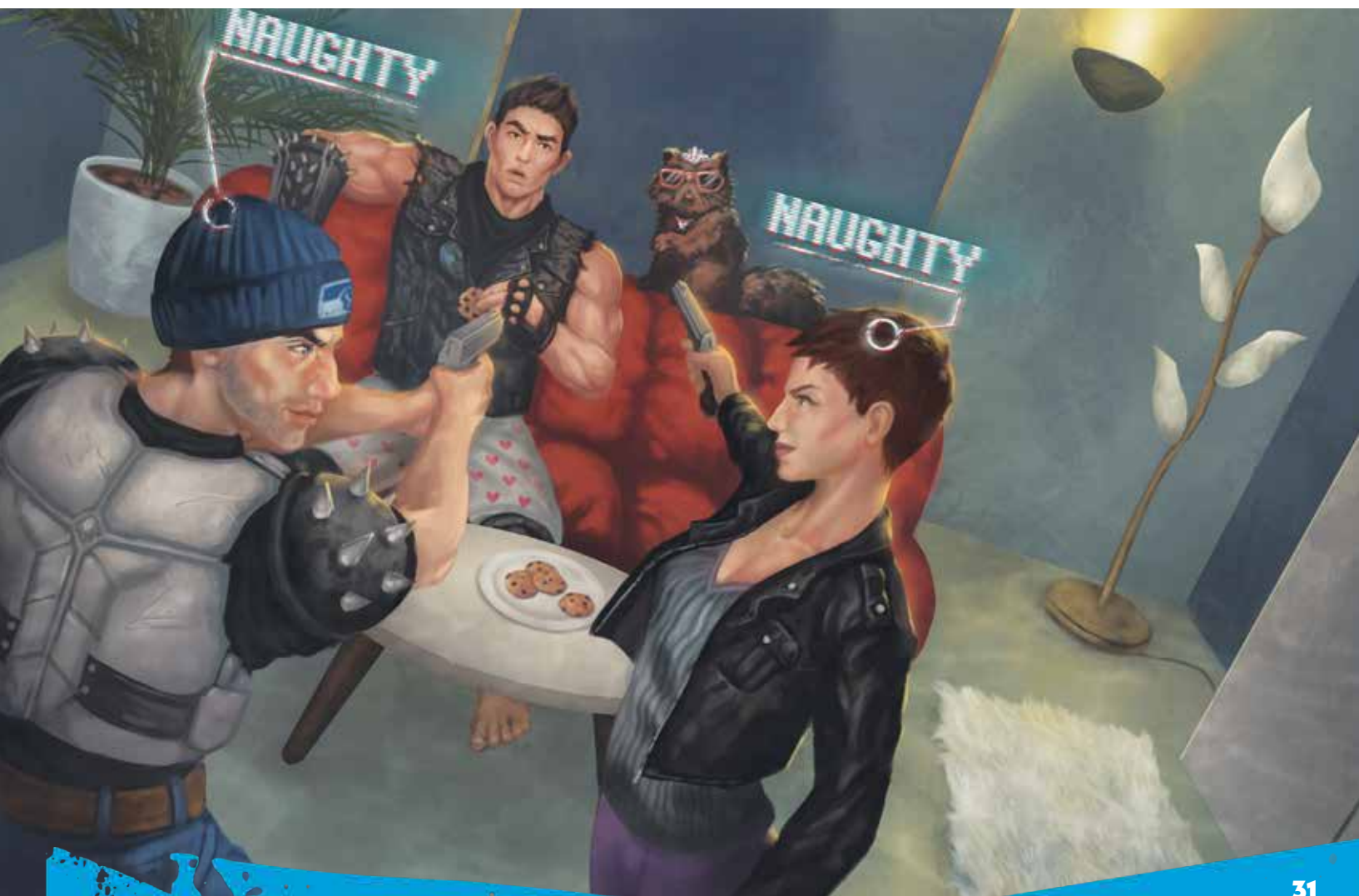
Fail by 1–2 (Near Miss Fail): A Failure, but there's still a chance to save the effort. When this result occurs, the GM announces a "Near Miss" to allow other players to help with an Intervene Action during combat (see *Crawler Reaction Phase*, p. 33).

Fail by 3–9 (Standard Fail): This is a normal Failure, such as missing a target or failing to Evade an attack.

Fail by 10 or more (Major Fail): A Failure to this degree comes with some manner of consequence, such as dropping a weapon or other important piece of equipment, losing footing (reducing Movement), running out of ammunition, or other penalty.

Achieving a Major Fail on an Evade Check, the crawler exposes a vulnerable spot which the Mob strikes. The crawler suffers additional damage from the attack equal to the current Floor Number and gains a Minor Injury Debuff after combat, once the adrenaline wears off.

Natural 1 (Critical Fail): On a roll of a Natural 1 (a 1 on the die without any modifiers), the crawler suffers the worst possible outcome. Consequences might include pummeling an ally instead of an enemy, breaking a weapon or important tool, or gaining a Debuff.



Getting a Critical Fail on an Evade Check, the crawler suffers twice as much damage and gains a Major Injury Debuff after combat. And they feel pretty dumb, too.

STARTING A COMBAT

When it looks like a combat scene or encounter is imminent, such as Mobs and crawlers in close quarters, establish the pre-combat situation by establishing the location and determining surprise.

ESTABLISH LOCATION

At the start of a combat scene or encounter, it's important to determine where everyone is located and what opportunities or challenges are present in the environment. It's important for the GM to describe the obvious terrain features at this point, along with any obvious threats.

Maps in Combat: Some groups love tactical maps. Others prefer a theater-of-the-mind style, imagining the Action without a grid. Many groups fall somewhere in between, using tokens or painted miniatures to show general positioning—who's in striking range, who's a Move Action away, and who's farther out.

Use whichever approach works best for your table. For groups that enjoy tactical play and precise movement, you can use either square- or hex-based maps. The most common scale is 1-inch squares or hexes representing 5 feet, which has become a standard for tabletop RPGs.

For vehicles or larger-scale encounters, a useful scale is 1 inch represents 50 feet.

When using square maps, moving or attacking diagonally works the same as moving or attacking into an orthogonally adjacent space, with no extra cost or measurement required. Bonus points if you knew what "orthogonally" meant before reading this section.

DETERMINE SURPRISE

Normally, combat occurs when Mobs encounter the crawlers and the Mobs go first. Cunning crawlers may make use of their Skills, such as Stealth and Ambush, to get the drop on foes.

Crawlers act first in combat when they surprise their foes and have a free Action to spend before the normal flow of combat begins. The surprise round only happens once.

STEP-BY-STEP COMBAT

A combat scene unfolds in the following steps:

- 1. Mob Action Declaration:** The GM announces what the Mobs are doing, including their movement, whom they plan to attack, and how.
- 2. Crawler Reaction Phase:** Players can choose to use Actions on Interrupts.
- 3. Mob Attack Resolution:** Mobs complete their attacks and other Actions.
- 4. Crawler Action Phase:** Players spend their remaining Actions and finish their turns.
- 5. Clean Up:** Any effects that happen at the end of the round occur, all combatants reset their Action count, and a new round begins at Step 1 if needed.

STEP 1: MOB ACTION DECLARATION

The GM announces the Mobs' Actions during this step, including their general movement, which attacks or other Actions they will use, and whom they are targeting.

Low-quality Mobs each have 1 Move Action and 1 other Action per round, usually an Attack, typically dividing their attacks evenly between the crawlers in range.

High-quality Mobs, such as Elites and Bosses, are exceptionally dangerous. They have 1 Action per crawler each round, unless their Stat Block says otherwise. They continue to have this many Actions even if some crawlers are out of commission or dead. Now you know why you might need to run away, dragging your dying friends behind you.

DETERMINE TARGETING

Mobs can target based on a variety of factors, such as whom they perceive to be the greatest threat, who is closest, which crawlers have items or effects that dissuade or enrage them (such as Fairy-class Mobs against a crawler with a Goblin Pass), or, my personal favorite, randomly.

STEP 2: CRAWLER REACTION PHASE

After all Mobs have announced their movement, Actions, and targets, the crawlers can use Interrupt Actions to react prior to the resolution of Mob Actions. Spending Actions during this phase counts against the two Actions that each crawler gets every round, and determining when to spend Actions is a significant part of game strategy.

And if you screw it up, you might die. No pressure, right?

The Interrupt Actions that crawlers can take include:

Evade (Interrupt): The most common Interrupt Action, a crawler who takes this Action attempts to avoid attacks against them. The player rolls a separate Evade Check against each attack directed at their crawler, so if 3 attacks are directed at the crawler, the player makes 3 Evade Checks. The Difficulty of the Evade Check is determined by the Mob's attack value (see Step 5 for additional details). Successful evasion of an Area of Effect attack reduces the damage by 50%.

Intervene (Interrupt): The most flexible Interrupt, Intervene allows one crawler to help another at the cost of an Action. The Intervening crawler rolls 1d6 and can add the result of that die roll to another crawler's Action after the result is announced. This can be used on any

d20 Check (except Stat Checks), but is most useful for turning a Near Miss Fail result into a Success.

Catcher (Interrupt): Heroic, foolish, or tough crawlers prize this Interrupt Action, which allows them to take the hit for an adjacent ally (using their Step to get into position if needed). The Catcher crawler cannot Evade the attack they're catching.

Healing (Interrupt): A crawler can take this specialized version of the Cast a Spell or Use a Hotlist Item Action to activate a Spell or item with the healing trait. This healing applies *before* the Mob deals its damage (because we're nice like that). The Healing Action may also be used as a normal Action during the crawler Action Phase, which also allows a crawler to Make a Check, such as First Aid.

Taunt (Interrupt): Bold crawlers use this Action to make an INT-Opposed Taunt Skill Check against a Mob, drawing them to attack the crawler using Taunt instead of the Mob's original target. After using the Taunt Action, the crawler may then choose to spend an Action to Evade those and any other attacks.

Once all players have finished their Interrupt Actions, play proceeds to Step 3.

FOR THE GM: MOB ON MOB ACTION

Clever crawlers may find ways to cause Mobs to attack each other or Bosses. When this sort of NPC-versus-NPC action occurs, the GM can simply decide. Pick David or Goliath depending on what makes things the most interesting. If the story doesn't suggest a clear winner, directly compare the Attack and Evade (or other relevant Stats) between the NPCs to determine the outcome, assuming the NPC with the better value wins. If you want to play to find out (remember that GMs don't roll Attack Skill Checks), roll 1d12 and use Table 6. It's skewed toward the more powerful NPC but allows for the underdog to come out on top sometimes.

TABLE 6: NPC VS. NPC

ROLL OR CHOOSE	EFFECT
1	The attacking NPC outright loses or misses badly, achieving a Major Fail, and everyone—other Mobs, Bosses, and crawlers—gains Advantage to attack it until the end of the round or a Debuff of the GM's choosing.
2–4	The attacking NPC misses or possibly just loses the fight.
5–8	The attacking NPC hits if its relevant Stat is higher than the defender's opposing Stat
9–11	The attacking NPC hits and deals damage as normal or possibly wins the fight.
12	The attacking NPC achieves an Amazing Success, dealing damage to the defender with a bonus equal to twice the Floor Number or a similar Buff or just emerges victorious.

Keep in mind that even if you stick with the static values, Mobs attacking other Mobs and missing still consume their Actions, which can be a huge swing in the crawlers' favor during an intense combat.

STEP 3: MOB ACTION RESOLUTION

In this step, the Mobs deal damage to the crawlers who either failed to Evade or didn't bother to Evade during Step 2. Any other effects from a Mob's attack, such as applying Debuffs, also apply now.

The GM rolls each attack's damage dice, adds the appropriate Stat Mod to the total, and applies any additional effects, such as Debuffs, from the attack. Crawlers apply their Damage Resistance (DR, see *Rules*, p. 42) to the attack before marking damage on their Health Bar (see *Damage and Healing* later in this section).

STEP 4: CRAWLER ACTION PHASE

Now players can use any remaining Actions for their crawler to strike back. Crawlers can take their Actions in any order and may even intermingle them. No initiative here! Crawlers may use both of their Actions to Attack if they wish. The Actions that players can take in this phase include:

ATTACK

A crawler strikes at a Mob with their fists or feet, a melee weapon, a ranged weapon, or a Spell. The crawler can swap the weapon in their hand for another weapon from their Hotlist as part of the Attack Action.

Choose a Target: Select a target within range. Most melee Weapon Skills have a range of 5 feet, and Weapon Skills with the Reach keyword have a range of 10 feet. Reach Weapon Skills cannot attack through occupied spaces, but they can attack diagonally through the corner between two spaces, as long as at least one of those spaces is unoccupied.

Ranged Weapon Skills list their maximum range, and there is no penalty for attacking a foe within that range. Ranged weapons and Spells that target a foe outside of their range automatically fail. Spell Skills must spend their Mana Points to activate the Spell now.

Determine Modifiers: The player and GM determine what modifications apply to the Skill Check (if any), such as benefits from Buffs, penalties from Debuffs, modifiers based on target size, and environmental challenges like low light or cover.

Make the Attack!: The player rolls their Weapon Skill Check.

To attack, roll $1d20 + \text{Skill Rank} + \text{Stat Mod}$ as usual. The target number for the attack is the Mob's Evade score, which is $10 + \text{DEX Mod} + \text{Floor}$.

The Stat Blocks of some Mobs may have additional modifiers. After the roll, the GM determines their crawler's degree of Success (and opportunity for an ally to take the Intervene Action if needed). If the attack hits, the player rolls damage based on their Attack or Spell Skill.

MELEE ATTACKS

Melee attacks use your STR to hit and damage.

RANGED ATTACKS

Physical ranged attacks use DEX to hit, some apply STR to damage, while others have no damage bonus.

Ranged attacks suffer Disadvantage if made within the melee reach of an enemy.

SPELL ATTACKS

Spells use INT to hit and damage.

Ranged Spell Attacks also suffer Disadvantage if made within the melee reach of an enemy.

AREA OF EFFECT ATTACKS

Attacks like the Fireball Spell or the Goblin Dynamite Skill deal damage over a wide area. These Area of Effect qualities are listed with the Attack Skill entry. When making an Area attack, the attacker makes a single attack roll against a foe of their choosing within range as usual, with the potential benefit of dealing damage to more creatures than just the target of the attack.

If the attack is Successful, the attacker rolls damage once and applies the full damage to all creatures, crawler and Mob alike, in the affected area (including the target of the attack). Resistances and DR reduce the damage as usual.

On Fail, most attacks have misfired and no creatures take any damage, unless it's a Critical Fail and it hits the wrong target. However, Area attacks like Fireball and Dynamite still land somewhere and deal damage to whatever is near the new impact area. Only Attacks that reference Figure 1 (like those two) in *Crawlers & Customization* p. 35 do anything on a Fail.

Some Area of Effect attacks also have a Splash damage area (not to be confused with everyone's favorite Otter stripper from the Penis Parade, Splash Zone), a radius from the initial blast which deals half as much damage to those in the area. Anyone caught in the splash zone of that damage applies DR and other effects normally.



A crawler affected by an AoE attack can Evade (if they spend an Action to do so), and may have situational modifiers like cover, elevation, etc. A victim who Evades an AoE attack reduces the damage by 50%. A successful Evade in the splash zone results in only 25% of the damage being applied. Such damage is rounded down as usual. Taking a Step during an Evade Check (or any Interrupt) is not fast enough to outrun an explosion, so you can't simply duck out of the affected area.

AREA OF EFFECT TYPES

Spells, weapons, items, Mobs, and Bosses use area of effect attacks in various ways. There are several different types of Areas:

- **Blast:** Extends outward in all directions from the target (or where the explosive landed) to the listed distance.*
- **Burst:** Extends outward in all directions from the caster to the listed distance.
- **Line:** Extends outward in a 5ft wide line from the caster to the listed distance.

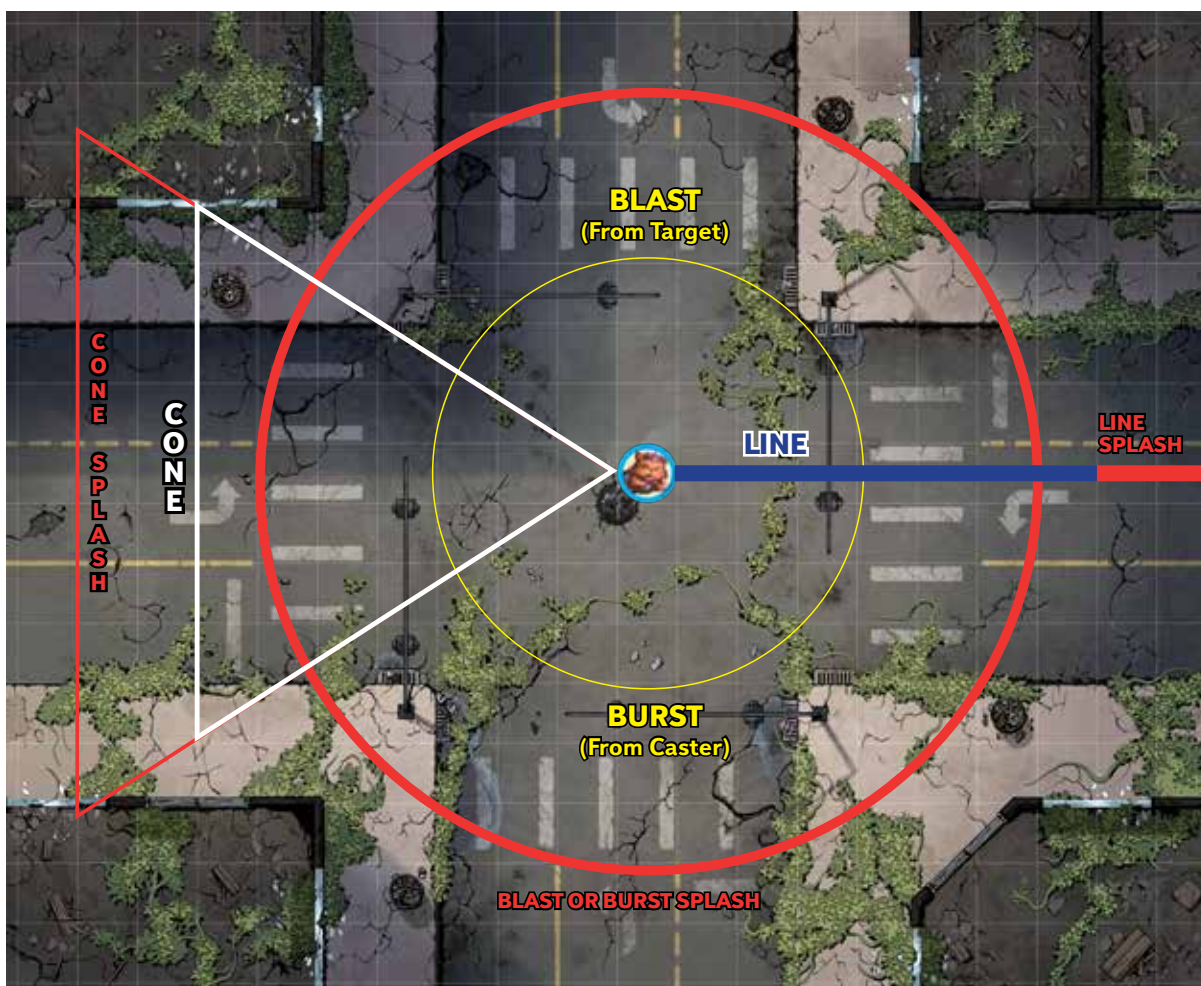
- **Cone:** Extends outward in a 60 degree arc from the caster to the listed distance.
- **+Splash:** Extends outward beyond the full-damage area, dealing half damage within the listed distance. This is an add-on to the Area types above, and extends in the same manner.

Example: A "20ft Cone +10ft Splash" means the Cone is 30ft in length. Victims in the first 20ft of the Cone take full damage, while victims in last 10ft Splash zone of the Cone take half damage.

**If you're using a battle map, the target or impact area of a "10ft Blast radius" is the origin of the Blast effect. From that 5ft x 5ft space, the Blast extends outward two spaces in every direction. If you're not tracking the exact position of each crawler, Mob, and other NPCs, you'll need to make a reasonable call on who is affected in any Area situation. See the image below for examples of Area attacks.*

ATTACK MODIFIERS

Several additional situations may alter the Evade score of a target or otherwise modify the attack.



COVER

Objects can get in the way of attacks made at greater-than-melee range, causing such attacks to be made with Disadvantage. Attacks made at melee range are unaffected by cover. Things that can provide cover include crates, terrain, cars, low walls, etc. If the attack misses, the cover might be destroyed, depending on how sturdy it is and whether your crawler is strong or has to have their mom do the heavy lifting.

ENVIRONMENTAL MODIFIERS

When attacking targets in Cover, Darkness, Severe Weather, Shifting Ground, or amid other penalties, an attacking crawler rolls with Disadvantage. Similarly, those with help from the environment, such as attacking from high ground, roll with Advantage.

SIZE

Crawlers roll Attack Skill Checks with Disadvantage when attacking a target 4 or more size classes smaller than them or with Advantage if the target is 4 or more larger. Also, when a big dude hits a little dude with a melee Attack with Disadvantage due to size, the big dude adds their size value to the damage. Table 7 shows these sizes.

TABLE 7: CREATURE SIZE

SIZE	SIZE NAME	CREATURE EXAMPLE
1	Tiny	Scatterer, Rat
2	Small	Cat, Raccoon
3	Petite	Goblin, Boar
4	Medium	Human, Wolf
5	Large	Horse, ManTauR
6	Huge	Elephant, Rhino
7	Colossal	Dinosaur, Dragon
8	Gargantuan	Kaiju

UNSEEN ATTACKERS

Creatures gain Advantage on Attack Skill Checks against targets that can't see them, such as a crawler who is hidden, invisible, or on the other side of a smoke cloud. Inversely, creatures suffer Disadvantage on Attack Skill Checks against targets they can't see.

DAMAGE

When a crawler hits with an attack, they deal damage, which starts with the base damage die determined by the Skill (higher Ranks grant additional base damage dice; see *Attack Skill* listings in *Crawlers & Customization*, p. 21–27), plus the appropriate Stat Mod. Some attacks add special effects alongside these extra dice.

Unarmed attacks deal low inherent damage but allow the combatant to add 1 Damage Effect to the attack. These include well-known abilities such as Powerful Strike, Iron Punch, and others from the novels. If the attack hits, the attack's damage dice are rolled, and then the chosen Damage Effect is applied.

After calculating total damage, the GM applies any DR and then marks off the Mob's HB.

CAST A SPELL

A crawler can spend an Action to cast a non-Attack Spell, paying its Mana cost and following the Spell Skill's instructions. There's no limit to the number of Spells that can be cast in a combat, provided the crawler has enough Actions and Mana. Too bad you picked a Barbarian class.

MAKE A CHECK

Many non-Attack Skills can be useful in combat, and a crawler can spend an Action to attempt the Skill during battle. If the GM requires a non-Attack Skill Check in the midst of battle, this generally doesn't require a crawler to spend an Action to perform, unless your GM doesn't understand the rules or they're feeling particularly spicy that day.

LOOK FOR CLUES

The Look for Clues Action is a specialized version of the Make a Check Action in combat that focuses on gathering information about a Boss (not regular Mobs) or the environment to give the whole party a leg-up. This can be performed as an Unopposed Perception, Investigation, or similar Skill Check.

On Success, the crawler discovers one piece of information about the Boss or area that will aid the party. Higher degrees of Success grant additional clues if available.

If multiple clues may be found, the crawler can specify what aspect of the scene (such as the Boss, the environment, or other features) to focus their Look for Clues Action on. For Bosses, this can be as specific as their weapon, their armor, or the brooch the Boss is wearing.

Clues can include vulnerabilities, resistances, attacks to look out for, what effect killing a Mob's leader might have, how to counter Debuffs inflicted by foes, environmental elements that would be useful in the fight, and more.

Ultimately, the GM decides which clue to give, so if they want to be a dick, that may not go so well for the crawlers. If we assume the GM isn't a megalomaniac, and perhaps they don't feel a clue is going to be useful



to the crawlers, they are free to just give each crawler Advantage on their next attack or Evade, depending on what the clue-seeker was most interested in.

HEALING

In addition to the Use a Hotlist Item Action or the Cast a Spell Action, a crawler can also use the Make a Check Action to use the First Aid Skill or any other means of healing in this phase. (See also the Healing Interrupt Action above in Step 4.)

NON-SKILL ACTIONS

During a combat scene, crawlers can also take a variety of Actions that don't require a Skill Check, including:

- **Call a Play:** A crawler proposes an Action for an ally to perform, such as attacking a specific target. The crawler rolls 2d6 and keeps the higher roll: the Called Play bonus.
When another crawler performs the proposed Action, the crawler who called the play can add the Called Play bonus to their ally's Skill Check total. If the Skill Check is Successful without the bonus, the Called Play bonus adds to their damage roll instead.
- **Intervene:** During the Crawler Action Phase, a crawler can use the Intervene Action as well (see Step 2).
- **Move:** A crawler can spend an Action to travel up to their Move allotment.
- **Retrieve:** Pull an item from your Inventory to your hand or the floor, or add it to your Hotlist. You cannot use that item during your current Action.
- **Use a Hotlist Item:** A crawler selects a consumable item from their Hotlist, such as a potion or scroll, and uses it or withdraws another item. Remember that swapping weapons is free as part of the Attack Action.

STEP 5: CLEAN UP

New Achievement! You've punched some Mobs, cast some Spells, took some damage, and in doing so, you made a mess. You might just be getting the hang of this, crawler!

Reward: You get to clean up your own mess. I'm not your mother or your maid. Don't be lazy, and do it yourself.

During this step, the players and GM do the following:

- **Apply End-of-Round Effects:** Crawlers with any Buffs, Debuffs, the Regeneration Skill, and other effects apply them now in the order most beneficial to them.

- **Determine End of Combat:** If all combatants on one side or the other are defeated, the combat ends. If not, combat continues at Step 1.

CRAWLER VS. CRAWLER COMBAT

Crawlers must reach a stairwell in any way possible to survive to the next floor, and that requires leveling up, learning cool Spells, and acquiring great gear (among other considerations). For some enterprising crawlers, the easiest way to advance through the dungeon isn't to brave deadly Mobs and Bosses but rather to kill other crawlers while their guard is down.

A KEY DISTINCTION: CRAWLER VS. CRAWLER, NOT PLAYER VS. PLAYER

All of the players in a party in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* are explicitly working together, especially here in the Starter Set. When we refer to Crawler vs. Crawler conflict, it transpires between the Player Crawlers and other surviving crawlers in the World Dungeon who are controlled by the GM (GMCs).

If forced by a Mob to attack a party member, the target automatically gets an Evade Check at no Action cost.

Specific player vs. player rules will be introduced in future *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* expansion books.

FIGHTING OTHER CRAWLERS

Fighting GM-controlled crawlers (GMCs) works just like fighting Mobs, aside from that empty feeling that yawns open inside your chest when you've killed another human in cold blood. But don't worry—if you keep doing it, you can try to fill that chasm with enough dead bodies that you'll feel normal again. It's science.

KILLING A CRAWLER

As usual, when a crawler loses the last slot of their Health Bar, they die in a number of rounds equal to their CON Mod (see *0% Health Bar and Dying*, p. 42). If a Player Crawler lets them die, they gain a white Player Killer Skull above their head next to their name, which identifies them to all other characters in the dungeon as a Player Killer. Now everyone knows (or at least strongly suspects) they can't be trusted.

Keep in mind that only the crawler who delivers the killing blow gains the Player Killer title and the corresponding skull. Deflecting damage from a third party also does the trick. Use your imagination, and your GM just might let you get away with murder. If you don't get the credit, the only reward you earn is the ignoble ability to loot the corpse as if it were a Mob, but note that the actual Player Killer gets first dibs, just like with Mobs.

COMBAT EXAMPLE

In this scene, the crawler party has spent enough time in the area to know that a Gnoll patrol will pass through this part of the Second Floor.

Ron (playing Park): Since I've got the Ambush Skill, I'm gonna lead the party to take up position for the incoming Gnolls.

Joe (The GM): Sounds like a good plan. There's plenty of cover in this part of the Neighborhood. Please mark your crawlers' locations, and the Gnolls will be coming from the left side of the map. Since everyone needs to get into position, this will be a Party Ambush Skill Check.

POSITIONING

Before a combat scene or encounter begins, the players and GM determine where everyone is in the encounter. In this case, the players set their miniatures in locations on a battle map, and based on the crawlers' foreknowledge of the situation, the GM announces what direction the Gnolls are coming from. When playing without a battle map, the party and GM discuss what's in the location and establish a rough approximation of where everyone is before the Action kicks off.

Ben (playing Kai): I'm at Disadvantage for lacking the Skill, and we know how dexterous Kai is. I've got a 4.

Koda (playing Beatrix): You never disappoint. Beatrix gets a 16.

Ron: I've got an 18.

Andrew (playing Isabella): Isabella also lacks the Skill, but I've got a 11. 11 is good, right?

Paige (playing Brayden): We'll see. I've got a 14.

Joe: Alright, that's a Success against the Gnolls' Surprise Difficulty of 13.

PARTY SKILL CHECKS

The Ambush Party Skill Check here is Successful because three players (Ron, Koda, and Paige) met or beat the Difficulty of 13. Their accomplishment carries over to their less-Skilled party members (Ben and Andrew) and allows the party to succeed as a group.

Joe: As the Gnolls pass by, blissfully unaware of you and discussing their plan to get some Goblin hooch after their shift. You spring into violence, and each crawler gets one Action.

Ben: I'm gonna rush in and take on the captain.

Ron: How about you let me go first to soften them up with a hail of lead?

Ben: Great point. I'll wait for you and anybody else making ranged Attacks before I get in there.

TEAMWORK

In the Ambush, just like in Steps 2 and 4 of combat, the crawlers can act in whatever order works best. There's no initiative to worry about.

Ron: I've only got a few rounds left, but I'm going to soften up the captain with a shot from my Shotgun. Does a 26 hit?

Joe: Not only does it hit, but it's also an Amazing Success!

Ron: Great, that's an 8 on my Shotgun's d10 plus 2 extra for Amazing Success since we're on the Second Floor, for a total of 10.

AMAZING SUCCESS

When a player rolls 10 or more over the Difficulty, they gain an Amazing Success. In combat scenes, an Amazing Success on an Attack Skill Check adds bonus damage equal to the current Floor Number.

Joe: Great hit. You see that hit clears 20% of the Gnoll Captain's Health Bar.

Paige: Only 20%? Good thing we ambushed them! Brayden's gonna use that Ice Blast scroll he got in his last Loot Box on the captain, too.

Joe: Let's have it.

Paige: Only a 13 to hit.

Joe: That's a Near Miss...

Paige: Guys, I don't want this scroll to go to waste. It's the best item I got out of my last set of boxes. Can one of you help out?



Ben: I can.

Andrew: We need Kai up there taking hits, Ben. Isabella's got it. I've got a 4 on my Intervene die.

THE INTERVENE ACTION

The Intervene Action is flexible, allowing a player to use their Action to help another party member (hopefully) succeed. Intervene can only be used in combat and is a d6 roll by default.

Joe: With Isabella helping, you've got a Standard Success.

Paige: Thanks, Andrew. The scroll is Spell Skill Rank 6, so I've got 2d8—a 7 and a 5—plus Brayden's 4 INT for a total of 16.

Joe: Good hit. That's another 30% down on the Groll Captain. He's at 50% and pissed!

Ben: Kai will take his Action to Move and block as many of the Gnolls as he can.

Koda: Beatrix isn't that brave, but she's going to Move, too, to base the wounded captain.

Joe: With that, the surprise Actions are over, and your crawlers are back to their normal 2 Actions. The Groll Captain, wounded and in a rage, is going to slice at Beatrix with both of his swords. Three Gnolls are going to dogpile Kai with their spears, and the other two are going to run past him to get at Park and Brayden with their spears. Any reactions?

STEP 1

Joe declares what all of his Gnolls are doing and whom they're going to attack. With that established, combat moves to Step 2, where the crawlers react.

Koda: Beatrix doesn't want to get hit by this captain once, let alone twice. I'll spend an Action to Evade.

Paige: Brayden doesn't have the Health to deal with a Groll, so I'll also spend an Action to Evade.

Ben: Wait, Paige. Brayden's fragile. Let's see if Kai can Taunt Brayden's Groll away and save you an Action to unleash a big Spell on the others.

Paige: I mean, I do have the Mana since I used the scroll...

Ron: Park's not afraid of a spear and needs to keep shooting. No Evade Action from me here.

Andrew: No Gnolls for Isabella? That's fine. I'm happy to take 2 Attack Actions later. I pass.

Joe: Let's see Beatrix's Evade Check and Kai's Taunt.

Ben: "Get away from him and fight me, you fur-faced coward!" Alright, let's hope the dice back it up—sweet. A 16, total.

Joe: The Groll, who was heading toward Brayden, whips its head back at Kai and snarls. You've got his attention now! Koda, you're up.

Koda: Alright, Beatrix slides out of the way easily with an 18 on Evading the first blow, then she ducks to avoid the second slash—oh, no, a Natural 1. I can AI favor that away, right?

Ron: Any roll except a Natural 1, Koda. Sorry. But you'll probably make the highlight reel—if you live!

ENDING A STEP

Once all crawlers decide whether to use their Actions on Interrupts and make their die rolls, the Crawler Reaction Step ends. When players start with the game, it can be helpful to make a "last call" for Actions to make sure nobody misses their chance before ending the Phase.

Joe: Ron's right. Alright, a Critical Fail nets Beatrix 9 Slashing damage and a Major Injury after the fight.

CRITICAL FAIL WHILE EVADING

When a player gets a Natural 1 on their Evade Check, their crawler suffers a Major Injury after the adrenaline of the fight runs out. Even with a trained medic in play like Ron's crawler, Park, injuries require time to heal. See *Injuries*, p. 46 for more.

Koda: Ouch, with my 1 DR, that's 8 damage against my HB slot of 2. There goes 40% of her Health Bar!

Joe: And the four other Gnolls cackle and stab at Kai. Since you didn't Evade, that's 4 stabs: 4, 5, 6, and 4 damage, all Piercing. The Gnolls look like they're used to working together to pin their prey in, but they aren't sure what to do about somebody dumb enough to just take the hits.

CONTEXT CLUES

As this isn't a Boss encounter, the crawlers can't use the Look for Clues Action. Here, Joe describes the Gnolls' tactics based on the Mob's Pack Hunting trait—without giving away the specifics—as a storytelling element amid the combat.

Ben: Bracing with his wok-shield to turn aside the stabs, Kai toughs it out. With his 3 DR, that's 1, 2, 3, and 1 damage, and my tough chef's Health Bar slots are 4s now. So Kai's surrounded, but he's not in trouble yet.

Joe: Well done! Alright, the last Gnoll gets to Park, also dealing 5 damage.

Ron: Taken, and 10% of Park's HB is gone.

Joe: Okay, crawlers, it's your turn to kill, kill, kill!

Koda: Beatrix is going to teach the Gnoll Captain the meaning of pain, spending my last Action to Attack. Oh, yeah! That's a Crit. With my 5 Ranks in Longsword, that's 4d8 – 3, 5, 7, and 4—plus her 3 STR for 22 Slashing damage.

CRITICAL HITS

Koda gets a Natural 20 on Beatrix's attack, which doubles the number of dice rolled. The Longsword deals 1d8+STR damage, plus another 1d8 for the Skill's Rank 5 Upgrade. With the Natural 20, these dice double to 4d8+STR. Unlike other attacks, Koda doesn't need to ask if Beatrix hits—a Natural 20 always hits. Similarly, a Natural 1 always misses, but no need to worry about that here!

Joe: With that, the Gnoll Captain yelps and is down to 10%!

Andrew: Isabella moves to bat clean-up, using her combat tai chi to knock the Gnoll Captain's lights out.

Joe: This is her Pugilism Skill, right?

Andrew: Right, plus Iron Punch if I hit... which I don't, with a 9. I've got a second Action, so with a grunt of frustration, Isabella follows up her miss with another punch. Alright, a 14 this time!

Joe: Solid hit.

Andrew: Alright, 1d2+STR for the Pugilism, 1d2 for Iron Punch, then 1d4 for the Rank Damage Die for Iron Punch Rank 5. That's 2, 2, and 2... plus another 2 for Isabella's STR, so a total of 8 Bludgeoning damage.

RANK DAMAGE DICE

As crawlers increase their Attack Skills for both weapons and Spells, they gain additional upgrades. Sometimes the upgrade is a Rank Damage Die, which increases based on the crawler's current Skill Rank. See *Rank Damage Dice* in *Crawlers & Customization* (p. 22).

Joe: The second punch knocks the Gnoll Captain off his feet, and he crumples, dead.

0% HEALTH

When a crawler reaches 0% of their Health Bar, they gain the Dying Debuff and must be healed within a number of rounds equal to their CON or perish. When a Mob reaches 0%, they die and typically don't come back... unless there's necromancy afoot.

Ron: Okay, I've got one Gnoll on me, and there are four still on Kai. And I backed myself into a corner because it seemed like the best spot before the fight. I don't want to waste ammo on a shot with Disadvantage, so Park's going to swap to his Dagger, putting his Shotgun back into the Hotlist as part of the Attack. Aaaaand... a 15 hits, right?

Joe: Yep, the Captain had a 14, and these Gnolls aren't wearing as much armor.

Ron: Great. 4 on the d4 plus Park's STR makes it 6.

Joe: Park's Dagger meets some resistance against the Gnoll's armor but stabs past it. That's a devastating hit, and the Gnoll facing you is suddenly at 25% Health.

Ron: Let's see if I can finish him off with my second Action! Only a 9 total, though.

Joe: Your stab goes wide, and the bleeding Gnoll erupts in laughter at Park's incompetence.

Paige: Okay, if you're not going to Evade, Ben, I'm not gonna spend the Mana on Confusing Fog or anything. But I do have this Junior Custard-or-Fireball lotto ticket I just got from a loot box, and there are 4 targets right there.

Joe: 5 targets including your ally.

Paige: 5 targets! I can't *not* use it... right?

Ben: Yeah, you can put Kai in it. Maybe I'll get lucky and you'll scratch off custard.

FRIENDLY FIRE

Area Spells like Fireball and attacks like explosives don't care what team the people in the area are in. When preparing to put an ally in the Area, it's best to check if the player is okay with it before knowingly damaging party members. Or don't. Sometimes you gotta keep things interesting.



Paige: You know you're not that lucky. Alright, on a 1 it's Custard. On a 2, it's Fireball. And it's a 2!

Joe: Alright, where are you targeting your Rank 5 Fireball?

Koda: Good thing it's a junior. If it were the Rank 15 one from the novels, Andrew and I would be cooked, too.

Paige: I'm targeting the central Gnoll so I can hit them all. The Fireball Spell Skill notes that its Attack Skill Check is with Disadvantage since it moves slowly. To hit, I've got a 12 and a 16 for Disadvantage. So 12 plus 5 for the Rank 5 Fireball on the ticket and Brayden's 3 INT—that's a 20.

Joe: Standard hit on all of them.

Ben: Wait—I still have an Action left. Can I spend it to Evade at this point?

Joe: Sure can!

Ben: Ugh, only a 6.

Paige: It's a good thing Kai's tough. 2d12 gets me a 12 and an 8, plus Brayden's 3 INT is 23 damage to the central Gnoll, and it blasts out 5ft to hit Kai and the rest of the Gnolls.

Joe: Brayden incinerates all of the Gnolls, filling the chamber with the scent of burning fur. How's Kai doing?

Ben: Alright, 23 minus Kai's 3 DR is 20. Thankfully, out of the loot boxes that Brayden got the lotto ticket, Kai got the Hellfire Kitchen Butcher's Apron, which has a Fire Resistance External Buff. I'm definitely glad I picked it. So that halves the rest to 10, and Kai loses 2 Health Bar slots.

APPLYING DAMAGE RESISTANCE EFFECTS

When determining damage resistance effects, the player and GM always apply their DR first. After that, they apply resistance, immunity, and vulnerability. In this case, Kai doesn't have any immunities or vulnerabilities to apply.

Joe: Along with that, he's got the Burned Debuff because he lost an HB slot to it. Kai's taking 1d10+2 for the Debuff as we move to clean-up. That's 7 Fire damage that your DR doesn't prevent.

Ben: But my Fire Resistance from the External Buff still applies, so that halves it and I round down to 3 instead. Thankfully, Kai's only down one more Health Bar slot.

Joe: Yep, but as you're still on fire, you'll need to worry about putting yourself out and maybe running, as you hear another Gnoll patrol headed your way!

HEALTH MENU

Each character's Health Menu is accessible whenever they can access their HUD. The Health Menu is an extensive pie chart that indicates any active status conditions such as Buffs, Debuffs, and injuries. The crawler can drill down and see which areas are affected, as well as learn from the provided detailed explanations of injuries and the healing process. If the crawler sustains enough damage, the entire pie chart may blink red.

In the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game*, the Health Menu consists of the Health Bar, Mana, Buffs & Debuffs, and Injuries.

HEALTH BAR



Every creature in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* has a Health Bar (HB), which tracks their available Health and is determined by the CON Mod for each slot. Each slot represents physical toughness, mental fortitude, and emotional resilience.

Crawlers' HB is composed of 10 slots, and individual creatures can have fewer (such as common Mobs) or more (Bosses, Elites, and some NPCs) slots.



DAMAGE TYPES

Each instance of damage usually has a type, such as Bludgeoning, Piercing, or Slashing for physical damage and elemental types, such as Acid, Ice, or Fire. The damage types themselves do not have a specific effect on their own but are referenced for other effects such as resistance, vulnerability, and immunity.

The damage types in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game* are:

- Acid
- Bludgeoning
- Electric
- Fire
- Force
- Holy
- Ice
- Necrotic
- Piercing
- Poison
- Psychic
- Slashing
- Sonic

DAMAGE RESISTANCE

When a target takes damage, that damage total is reduced by their Damage Resistance (DR) first. The rest of the damage, if any, is applied to the victim's Health Bar.

There are two types of resistance: Damage Resistance and Elemental Resistance. Damage Resistance (DR) is resistance against all types of damage. A creature that has resistance to an elemental type, such as Fire Resistance, takes half as much damage of that type whenever they take damage.

DR and Elemental Resistance are gained via Armor (natural or worn), Magic, and Buffs. There is no resistance against the latent sense of self-disappointment lurking in the depths of your soul. Have you tried talking to someone?

DAMAGE VULNERABILITY

After resistance is applied, use any Damage Vulnerability. Creatures can have Damage Vulnerability to specific types of damage, such as a Fire Elemental being vulnerable to Ice damage.

A creature takes twice as much damage when they're vulnerable to that damage type.

DAMAGE IMMUNITY

Finally, calculate Damage Immunity. Creatures can have Damage Immunity to specific types of damage, such as a Fire Elemental being immune to Fire damage, so the old Earth saying "fight fire with fire" won't get you very far here.

A creature reduces any damage to zero when it is a type to which they are immune. They also ignore any additional effects that come from that damage, such as Debuffs.

APPLYING DAMAGE TO THE HEALTH BAR

After applying DR, Elemental Resistance, Vulnerability, and Immunity, apply that amount to the Health Bar. If the remaining damage is less than the value of one HB slot, the victim takes no damage. If the damage is higher, it is applied to the character's Health Bar (HB). Add up the numbers in each slot of your HB until the total is equal to or greater than the damage. Any damage that does not meet the value of a slot is lost.

Make sense? Let's play this out.



Example: Using the Health Bar above, the crawler needs to take 14 damage. That is more than 3, so they mark off an HB slot and still have 11 damage incoming, which is more than 3, so they repeat the process. After doing this 4 times, they have 2 damage incoming which is less than 3 so they stop, and that 2 extra damage is ignored. This attack has caused the crawler to lose 4 Health Bar slots, and their HB now shows 60% remaining.

To mark off a Health Bar slot, fill in or mark the triangle in the upper right of the slot with a pencil. Don't X through the CON Mod, or you'll erase it when you erase the damage mark. Mark off green to red (right to left), as that's how video game health bars typically work. When taking future damage, do not count the slots already marked off.

0% HEALTH BAR & DYING

If a crawler loses their last HB slot, they gain the Dying Debuff and must be healed to at least 10% to survive. While dying, a crawler can't take any Actions, Move, speak, or use their HUD (see HUD in *Atlas*, p. 6).

A crawler stays Dying for a number of rounds equal to their CON, after which point they die. Each time a dying crawler would take damage, and during Combat



Step 5: Clean Up, subtract 1 from the number of rounds they are dying.

Mobs die instantly at 0% HB. GM-controlled crawlers die as slowly as Player Crawlers do.

ACTIONS & HEALING FROM 0%

When a crawler's HB is reduced to 0%, they are unable to use any remaining Actions until healed. If another crawler heals them during Step 4 of the same round, they can immediately use any remaining Actions they had left. But maybe don't rely on your mostly dead companions to bail you out in that Boss fight.

HEALING

After crawlers take damage, they'll want to recover their lost Health. They can heal through magic, such as the Heal Spell that every crawler learns when they enter the World Dungeon, through potions and other items, and by resting or mending.

When a crawler receives healing, they add the restored Health to their current Health Bar, refilling bars as they recover. Crawlers cannot gain Health in excess of their Health Bar through healing.

Unlike damage, which requires calculations, healing is always done by slots. For example, the Heal Spell recovers 20% HB, so a crawler heals whatever the value of each HB is, whether that's 2 Health (2 at 1 Health each) or 20 Health (2 slots at 10 Health each).

Spells and items specifically say either how many Health Bar slots or how much Health a crawler heals, making application easy in the midst of stressful situations like combat.

RESTING

Crawlers can also heal without using Mana or items, instead relying on the most valuable resource in the World Dungeon: time. By spending time resting in a saferoom, crawlers regenerate their Health Bar and Mana.

Doing so is often accomplished by sleeping in a saferoom's private room but can also occur from time taken doing nothing but relaxing, eating, chatting, and watching the recap show, but with no manual labor more strenuous than some calming crochet.

Crawlers heal based on the amount of time they rest:

- **Short Rest (2 hours):** Heal 5 Health Bar slots. Crawlers also regenerate half of their total Mana

(rounded down), so if they have 15 Intelligence, they regain 7 Mana.

- **Long Rest (8 hours):** After a long rest, a crawler is as good as new with a full Health Bar and Mana. A long rest also removes all instances of the "Fatigued" Debuff.
- **Full Day's Rest (30 hours):** Required to recover from long-term injuries (see *Injuries*, p. 46), a full day of rest also recovers their full Health Bar and all Mana.

Crawlers don't always need to rest to recover. For every full hour spent outside of combat or other stressful situations, they mend their wounds and recover 1 HB slot and 5 Mana.

But don't linger too long! Time spent lazing about is time you're not out there grinding, leveling up, and making a splash for viewers at home.

OTHER FORMS OF HEALING

In addition to using items and Spells, Skills and Buffs found on or implemented into gear can aid a crawler in recovering Health and Mana, such as the Regeneration Skill (see *Crawlers & Customization*, p. 33) and the Recovery Buff (see *Bufs*, below).

BUFFS & DEBUFFS

Aside from the perils of damage, crawlers frequently gain or suffer status effects that change how they perform. These are called Buffs and Debuffs, respectively.

Bufs make crawlers stronger, faster, tougher, or otherwise harder to kill. Debuffs do the opposite and are typically applied as a side-effect of taking damage. The dungeon applies both with equal enthusiasm and leaves the mess for crawlers to sort out.

BUFFS

Bufs are positive effects that provide some benefit to a crawler. Bufs are typically granted by potions, Spells, and gear. If a Buff has a duration and/or a cooldown, it must be activated to gain the effects. Bufs come in two forms: Internal Bufs and External Bufs.

INTERNAL BUFFS

An Internal Buff is one that affects the crawler without interfering with others. The most common Internal Bufs increase Stats or Skills.

Here are some examples of Internal Buffs:

- **Anti-Piercing:** Negates the Armor Piercing quality from attacks against the crawler.
- **Good Sleep:** Gains + Floor Number to all of a crawler's Stats for 30 hours.
- **Invisible:** An Invisible creature can't be targeted by anything that requires sight, and their equipment and gear are also concealed. An Invisible creature also benefits from Unseen Attackers benefits; see p. 36.
- **Iron Skin Potion:** Doubles the crawler's DR for 30 minutes.
- **Recovery Buff:** Restores a crawler to full Health (once per 5 hours).
- **Replenish Buff:** Regain INT Mana every 10 minutes.
- **Restore Buff:** Restores a crawler to full Mana (once per 5 hours).
- **Rooted in Place:** Cannot be forcibly pushed, pulled, slid or otherwise moved around.
- **Sticky Feet:** Grants a crawler a Climb Movement for a number of minutes equal to their DEX.

EXTERNAL BUFFS

While normal Buffs apply all the time, External Buffs kick in when a particular trigger occurs. When the trigger occurs, the player can choose whether the Buff activates or not (useful when the effect has a cooldown). Activating an External Buff doesn't generally require an Action, though some potent effects may require a specific Action that is resolved like an Interrupt.

Here are some examples of External Buffs:

- **Damage Reflection:** When a crawler loses a specific number of HB slots, this Buff deals 1 HB slot of damage to the attacker. Some versions of this Buff can direct the damage elsewhere (as in the case of Florin's least favorite External Buff).
- **Resistances & Immunities:** When a crawler suffers a type of damage, they can activate this External Buff to instantly prevent damage.
- **Safe Fall:** When a crawler falls by a particular distance or more, this External Buff activates to prevent Bludgeoning damage from falling and has the crawler land in a classic superhero pose instead.

THE RULE OF THREE

Crawlers can have a maximum of three External Buffs active at one time. If they have access to more than three, the player chooses which three are active at

the start of the crawling day. Write them down on the External Buffs section of your character sheet.

Typically, those are the Buffs that will be most useful to the crawler until the end of their next long rest. If a crawler gains access to a new External Buff during their adventuring day, they can change which External Buffs they have active during a short rest.

DEBUFFS

Debuffs are negative effects that affect the creature they're inflicted upon, such as limiting their options, applying Disadvantage to Checks, or dealing ongoing damage until the Debuff ends. There is no limit to the number of Debuffs a creature can be affected by at once.

A creature cannot be affected by the same Debuff more than once at the same time unless the Debuff entry says "Stackable." When a creature has Stackable Debuffs, they all apply their effect cumulatively.

DEBUFFS ON MOBS OR NPCs

When Debuffs are applied to Mobs or NPCs, they have the same effect as when a crawler gains one. However, because the GM doesn't roll d20 Checks (remember?), they behave differently. The GM applies the following changes when a Debuff grants one of the listed penalties.

- **Damage:** Damage from the Debuff is applied during Step 5: Clean Up.
- **Disadvantage:** The Difficulty of the Mob's Action, Stat Mod, or similar function is reduced by 5 when a crawler makes a Check against it. In the case of an attack, the crawler gains a free Evade Check vs. the Disadvantaged Action. If they fail that free Check, they may still spend an Action to Evade as usual and try again.
- **-X Skill Penalty:** Reduce the Mob's Difficulty by the amount of the penalty.

DEBUFF DURATIONS

All Debuffs have a duration, which is the amount of time or the conditions that must occur before the Debuff ends. Some Actions, items, or abilities may end a Debuff early such as dropping and rolling or leaping into water to put out a fire. The GM may also rule that a Debuff ends early if circumstances change.

If a Debuff applies damage to a crawler that would drop them to 0% on their Health Bar, they can make a CON Stat Check vs. Difficulty 10 + Floor during Step 5:


TABLE 8: DEBUFFS

DEBUFF NAME	EFFECT	DURATION
Blood Trail	You take 1d6+F at the end of each round. Stackable.	Until cured with a bandage or a First Aid Skill Check.
Burned	You take 1d10+F Fire damage at the end of each round.	Until the end of combat or 5 minutes. As an Action, a victim may perform a DEX Stat Check vs. Difficulty 10 + Floor to extinguish the flames.
Drowning	You take 1d6+F damage at the end of each round.	Until your head is above water.
Dying	You are at 0% HB. Your CON Mod is how many rounds you have before you die. Subtract 1 from this countdown value at the end of each round. Additionally, each time a Dying Crawler would take damage from any source, they instead subtract 1 from the countdown value.	Until you die or heal at least 1 HB slot.
Enraged	You are in a state of extreme uncontrolled fury. You may only perform Attack and Move Actions.	Until the end of 2 rounds or 20 seconds.
Fatigued	You have a –1 penalty on all Checks and your Move is halved. Stackable.	Until the end of a long rest.
Held	You are actively being held. You can't use Move Actions or take a Step but may still twist your body to Evade. Attacks against a Held foe are made with Advantage.	Until you are released by whatever is holding you, or you escape. Make a STR-Opposed DEX Stat Check or Escape Artist Skill Check. If the "holder" is using Wrasslin', see <i>Crawlers & Customization</i> (p. 24).
Long-Term Major Injury	You take a –5 penalty to all Checks.	Until the end of a full day of rest.
Long-Term Minor Injury	You take a –2 penalty to all Checks.	Until the end of a long rest.
Major Injury	You take a –5 penalty to all Checks. Gaining a Major Injury a second time changes it to a Long-Term Major Injury.	Until the end of a long rest.
Minor Injury	You take a –2 penalty to all Checks. Gaining a Minor Injury a second time changes it to a Long-Term Minor Injury.	Until the end of a short rest.
Muted	You can't speak or cast Spells.	Until the end of the combat or 5 minutes.
Poisoned	You take 1d8+F Poison damage at the end of each round. Stackable.	Until treated with an antidote.
Paralyzed	You can't take any Actions.	Until the end of the next round.
Queasy	If your next Action requires a roll, it's made with Disadvantage.	At the end of the next Action you take.
Sepsis	You're Staggered (see below) and take 1d10+F Poison damage at the end of each round.	As Staggered, and the damage continues until you're healed.
Shit-Faced	You make all your Checks with Disadvantage.	Until the end of 10 minutes.

DEBUFF NAME	EFFECT	DURATION
Shocked	You lose your next Action.	Once you forfeit that Action.
Sore as Shit	You suffer a –1 penalty to all rolls.	Until the end of 1 hour.
Staggered	The next Action you take can't be a Move, and if it is an attack, its Check is made with Disadvantage. You can't take a 10ft Step with your next Action.	At the end of the next Action you take.
Stiff Legs	You can't take 10ft Steps.	Until the end of the combat or 5 minutes.
Stunned	You gain Disadvantage on your next Check.	Once you make a Check.
Take Down	You fall prone. While prone, all Attacks made against you are made with Advantage.	Use your 10ft Step to stand.
Terrified	You can't take Move Actions or 10ft Steps. You make all attacks with Disadvantage.	Until the end of the next round, or you take at least 1 HB slot damage.
The Taint	You can't be healed.	Until the end of combat or 5 minutes.
Wozy	You can't add your DEX Mod to Attack or Evade Checks.	Until the end of the next round.

Clean Up. This Stat Check doesn't require an Action but occurs automatically before fatal damage. On a Success, the Debuff ends, and the crawler avoids the damage.

DAMAGE-DEALING DEBUFFS

When a Debuff deals damage to a crawler, it occurs during Step 5: Clean Up of each combat round. Damage from Debuffs bypasses DR, but other resistances and immunities apply as normal.

LIST OF DEBUFFS

Table 8 lists many Debuffs you might encounter on the Tutorial Floors, including the Debuff's name, its effect, and its default duration.

INJURIES

Injuries are a specific type of Debuff gained through significant damage, such as badly failing to Evade an attack, suffering an especially powerful or vicious Mob's attack effect, and other catastrophic efforts.

There are two main types of injuries: normal and long-term. The most common way for an injury to progress from a simple injury to a long-term injury is to suffer the same severity of injury multiple times. For example, if a crawler sustains a Minor Injury and suffers another, it becomes a long-term Minor Injury.

All injuries are most commonly cured with rest time in a saferoom.

- **Minor Injury:** The crawler suffers –2 to all Checks. A normal minor injury lasts until the crawler completes a short rest, while a Long-Term Minor Injury requires a long rest for full recovery.
- **Major Injury:** The crawler suffers –5 to all Checks. A normal Major Injury requires a long rest to recover from, while a long-term Major Injury requires a full 30 hours of rest for full recovery (see *Resting*, p. 43).

While some especially potent magic found on the later floors or from high-tier Loot Boxes may help crawlers recover from injuries faster, such magic is rare in the Tutorial Floors.

MANA

In addition to Health, crawlers access their Mana—the energy used to cast Spells—through the Health Menu. When crawlers enter the World Dungeon, they gain Mana Points equal to their Intelligence Stat plus access to the Heal Spell.

Crawlers regain Mana by resting, consuming Mana Toast (fuck you) available in some saferooms, consuming Mana Potions, and other ways. For more about casting Spells and Mana, see *Spell Skills in Crawlers & Customization* (p. 36).



EQUIPMENT

To survive the World Dungeon, the crawlers will find and use all manner of gear.

INVENTORY

The crawler's Inventory is accessed through their HUD (see *HUD* in *Atlas*, p. 6), and items in the Inventory are neatly categorized with key information. Items in the Inventory are weightless, so crawlers don't need to worry about encumbrance.

Outside of combat, items can be retrieved from the Inventory at the speed of thought, appearing in the crawler's hand, Hotlist, or on the floor in front of them. To transfer an item to another crawler or a marketplace, crawlers must physically hand it over, while marketplaces handle transfers digitally without touching the item.

There are a few limits on what crawlers can put into their Inventory:

- **Living Creatures:** If a crawler attempts to put a living creature into their Inventory, it dies. However, magical pet carriers make it possible for pets to take a time-out there.
- **Too Heavy:** A crawler must physically pick up an item for 4 seconds, unaided, in order to place it in their Inventory (see below).
- **Loose Liquids:** Let's just get this one out of the way now (instead of on the Fourth Floor) so no one gets too clever for their own good. If you want to store liquids, put the liquid in a container first.
- **Active Volatile Items:** An active, burning, ticking, or fusing explosive that is within 3 seconds of detonating cannot normally be stored in a crawler's Inventory. Three seconds is enough time to give it a toss, so buck up.
- **Items in Zero Zones or Outside the Dungeon:** Crawlers cannot typically pick up and store items in their Inventory while in the production facilities of the various interview shows or at CrawlCon. Anything that they can carry in their hands or wear (and get past the guards) can be brought back to the dungeon.



LIFTING WEIGHT

In the Dungeon, the biggest limitation for what crawlers can add to their Inventory is whether they can lift it. A crawler can lift up to their Strength score $\times 15$ in pounds. Animal crawlers don't even have to touch items to put them into their Inventory, but they have the same lifting maximum.

THE HOTLIST

Spells and items a crawler needs to have at the ready can be stored in their Hotlist, which is a special part of their Inventory designed for quick access. By default, each crawler's Hotlist contains 10 slots for items, Spells, and anything else the crawler wants to access quickly. Crawlers can spend an Action to activate something from their Hotlist (see *Actions*, p. 19).

If a crawler's Hotlist is full, they must remove or swap an entry from their Hotlist to replace it. A crawler can swap an item in their hands for the item in the Hotlist as part of the Use a Hotlist Item Action. If a crawler swaps their currently equipped weapon to another weapon on their Hotlist, they swap for free as part of the Attack Action.

GEAR SLOTS

Crawlers are limited to the amount of gear they can wear or benefit from at any given time. This is enforced by the division of gear into Gear Slots. Each Gear Slot can contain at most one clothing item, except for the Accessories slot, which can contain up to 10 items.

Only the items in these slots give crawlers bonuses of any kind, and items in a crawler's Inventory do not grant any bonuses. Each item that can be equipped specifies which Gear Slot it occupies.

Example: A crawler has collected four helmets, each with a different bonus. The crawler can wear only one of them, and only its bonuses apply while the others rest in the crawler's Inventory. And no, Dave, you can't wear four helmets.

The Gear Slot locations and examples of items that usually reside there include:

- **Head:** Items worn on the head or neck, such as helmets, bandanas, and cunning hats.
- **Torso:** Shirts, blouses, jerkins, and armor usually occupy this slot.
- **Arms:** Bracers and elbow pads make your puny arms look bigger than they really are.
- **Legs:** Pants, jeans, skirts, kilts, and boxers.

- **Feet:** Shoes, sandals, and boots go here.
- **Hands/Holding:** This one's a little different as you may both wear gloves (or similar) and hold things in your hands. One item per hand, and one pair of gloves. If you carry a Shield, that uses up a Holding slot. If a weapon has "Limitation: Two-Handed," you cannot hold anything else.
- **Accessories:** These include rings, amulets, brooches, tattoos, patches, piercings, and other items that don't fit neatly into another slot. Additional items include belts and capes, which a crawler may have a maximum of one each.

WEALTH

Wealth is tracked in the Inventory system in the denomination of gold coins, which all fit into one slot in a crawler's Inventory. These coins are accepted almost everywhere in the World Dungeon, though some merchants may prefer to barter items for items instead of dealing with currency.

MISCELLANEOUS JUNK

The World Dungeon is full of set dressing and other assorted crap that might be useful at some point, but rather than detail every item, most items are considered Miscellaneous Junk, and crawlers will find it nearly everywhere in the dungeon.

This junk is great for crafting (see *Crafting*, p. 49), and crawlers who need an innocuous item, such as a cheese grater, can spend one point of Misc. Junk to find one among their veritable garage sale of goods. So don't be shy about picking up whatever random stuff you find lying around. You never know when it might come in handy—or footsie.

ITEM RULES

The following items have specific rules.

POTIONS

Potions are single-use items that create a magical effect when consumed. If a crawler has a potion in their Hotlist, they can gain its effect without needing to physically drink it, though they must be conscious and not impaired, Dying, etc. Of course, if they want to make a show of it, they can manifest the potion in their hand and drink it down in the same moment.



In combat, you must spend an Action to “drink” a potion or to pour it into a nearby party member’s gullet. Healing potions of all varieties can also be consumed as an Interrupt. Outside of combat, a crawler needs but a free moment to consume it.

Crawlers cannot consume more than one potion every other round in combat. Attempting to do so will lead to Potion Sickness, which inflicts the Poison Debuff and lasts 15 seconds. Some potions have a higher cooldown and will be noted.

SCROLLS

Scrolls are a cheap and easy way to cast a particular Spell... once.

Scroll Spells have a set Rank, which is determined when the scroll is written down on special linen paper. The caster pays no Mana to cast the Spell and cannot change the Rank of the Spell being cast. After use, the scroll turns to dust and cannot be reused.

Scrolls adhere to the following naming convention: Scroll of SPELL NAME (Rank X), but replace “spell name” with the actual Spell name, and X with the Rank of the Spell. Like “Scroll of Confusing Fog (Rank 3).” Using a Scroll of Confusing Fog casts the Spell as though the crawler cast it themselves.

Scrolls are easy! Scrolls are a common reward in loot boxes, and crawlers can start making their own on the Fourth Floor when they gain access to personal spaces.

SPELLBOOKS

Spellbooks are incredibly useful items, even if the Spells don’t always appear that way at first. When a spellbook is read, it grants the crawler reading it a single Spell at a predefined Rank before disappearing (and it cannot be used again).

For instance, reading a spellbook of Hole will grant that Spell to the crawler who reads it. Depending on the book, the crawler’s Skill with their new Spell may range anywhere from 1 to 5. To randomly generate the Skill level, roll 1d6–1 with a minimum Rank of 1 for the purposes of the Tutorial Floors.



PETS & PET CARRIERS

Pets brought into the dungeon who don’t take an Enhanced Pet Biscuit to allow them to function as a crawler, like Prepotente or Grand Champion, Breed Winner Regional, National Winner Princess Donut the Queen Anne Chonk, face serious danger in the World Dungeon.

The *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game Core Rulebook* will contain rules for creating pet crawlers, but simple pets are best kept in pet carriers as they are rarely suitable for surviving the dungeon on their own. In addition to being relatively fragile, they lack many of the traits needed to survive and make sense of the dungeon.

Pets rewarded through the dungeon are a different case; while initially fragile, they reach full size and capability at level 15, though they can continue to increase in level beyond 15. Rules and statistics for dungeon-awarded pets will be found in the *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game Core Rulebook*.

Pets of either type must be put into a pet carrier, a special kind of container, to safely survive in a crawler’s Inventory (see limitations in *Inventory*, p. 47).

OTHER DUNGEON ACTIVITIES

In addition to interacting socially with other characters, exploring the World Dungeon environment, and fighting for their lives, crawlers also engage in a variety of other day-to-day activities.

CRAFTING

Crafting enables crawlers to combine or convert one or more things into another, empowering a crawler to create items they’re missing, such as a ladder to reach a higher place or a rope to descend into a monster’s lair. On the Tutorial Floors, there are no crafting tables or personal spaces, so crawlers’ ability to craft is limited to mundane items.

Anything that provides a crawler with benefits from wearing, holding, or otherwise possessing it is not mundane. The *Dungeon Crawler Carl Roleplaying Game Core Rulebook* details complete rules on Crafting.

COMMON ITEMS

Small household, grocery store items do not need to be crafted. Instead, spend one Misc. Junk point (see p. 48) and you recover that item from your Inventory: an egg-beater, rubber gloves, a roll of tape, or another item with limited moving parts—but *not* food and water.

After using it, either write it into your Inventory or toss it. You do not get the Misc. Junk point back. Each

point of Misc. Junk represents a kitchen drawer full of items that you just can't bring yourself to throw away. Hey, if you're that into collecting, I know a First-Floor Boss who would love to meet you. By the way, do you speak Spanish?

TABLE 9: ITEM SIZES

SIZE	EXAMPLE	MISC. JUNK NEEDED TO CRAFT
Tiny	Soda Can	1
Small	Toaster	4
Petite	Chair	16
Medium	Desk	32
Large	Statue	64
Huge	Dumpster	128
Colossal	Barn	256
Gargantuan	Grain Silo	512

UNCOMMON ITEMS

Most households have string, not rope. If you need something that isn't common or that wouldn't fit into a kitchen drawer, you can craft it. Table 9 is your guide to the size of the item you're crafting and how many points of Misc. Junk your project requires. Whatever you're making should have limited moving parts (no engines, electronics, fluid systems, etc.).

If you have the required amount of Misc. Junk on hand, you can balloon-animal whatever you need into existence. The GM or the blueprint you're following might require additional specific elements beyond Misc. Junk.

To Successfully create an uncommon item with no moving parts out of Misc. Junk, make an Unopposed Fabricate Skill Check. For items with moving parts, use Engineering instead. Each attempt takes a number of hours equal to "the size times the size." So a size 1 takes 1 hour, while a size 4 takes 16 hours.

If you succeed, the item is perfect and will last for the rest of your short life here in the dungeon.

If you fail, you messed it up. Determine by how much and consult Table 10 (below).

SALVAGING YOUR MESS

The amount you missed the roll by has a great effect on what can be salvaged from the project.



TABLE 10: SALVAGING JUNK

MISSSED BY	RESULT
10+	You messed things up so badly that there's nothing left to salvage from your mess.*
3–9	Salvage half of the Misc. Junk used, rounded down.*
1–2	Salvage all of the Misc. Junk used.

*More might be saved if you have the Salvage Skill (see *Crawlers & Customization*, p. 34).

WATCHING RECAPS

Every 30 hours, the corporation running the World Dungeon shares a recap show called *Dungeon Crawler World* that airs in all saferooms and across the galaxy. These recap shows feature a mixture of highlight reels, color commentary, and dungeon-wide announcements that are designed both for the galaxy's audience and crawlers themselves.

While watching the daily recap episodes, crawlers can gain important information about the World Dungeon: what Mobs and other monsters they might face, the challenges of existing Neighborhoods they might explore, and the personalities of other crawlers whom they might run into.

GUESTING ON SHOWS

Starting at the end of the First Floor, crawlers who survive against incredible odds, lean into the spectacle of the World Dungeon, and otherwise make a name for themselves can earn the opportunity to be additionally exploited by one of many shows that pay the Borant Corporation for the privilege of hosting crawlers for interviews.

Crawlers gain the benefit of being plucked out of the World Dungeon for a brief guest segment, where they can experience everything from a fair and measured conversation about the perils of the dungeon to traumatic reminders of every Failure they've made in the dungeon (and sometimes even beforehand) to be judged by the galaxy.

Guesting on shows is a specific type of roleplaying scene where crawlers don't have access to their HUD (see *HUD* in *Atlas*, p. 6), equipment, Spells, or the benefits of their magic items. Crawlers on shows may be forced to use their unenhanced statistics (especially



around admins), which will likely change their Stat Mod for Skill Checks. However, crawlers can generally still use their Skills; non-combat Skills that rely on INT and CHA are especially valuable.

Guesting on shows yields several benefits, including:

- **Gaining Fans:** A crawler being featured on a show opens them up to the show's audience, and an entertaining guest can gain a lot of fans by the end of a show. This tends to be a mutually beneficial arrangement as exciting guests earn fans while growing the show's reach, leading to invitations to take part in more shows. Crawlers who gain a large following from shows position themselves well for when sponsorships become available on lower floors.
- **Learning about the Crawl:** Shows can be a good way to learn about what's happening outside of the World Dungeon, including information about the entities in charge, galactic celebrities whom crawlers might run into on lower floors, and concepts like the Ninth Floor and Faction Wars. If the censors are sloppy, that is.
- **Learning about the Dungeon:** Shows discuss the perils of this season's dungeon, including Neighborhoods, Mobs, Bosses, traps, and other dangers to be on the lookout for.
- **Meeting New Crawlers:** A party of crawlers is rarely the only set of guests on a show, and taking part in a show together can lead to new allies—and rivalries.

- **Show Gift:** Some shows grant gifts to crawlers for participating, though most of these rewards are designed to go over well with the fans, so these aren't likely to be extremely helpful to crawlers.

Game Masters can find more information on running Shows in the *Game Master's Campaign Toolkit* (p. 72).

THE GREEN ROOM

Crawlers are teleported from the World Dungeon into these areas to prepare, usually with the aid of cleaning facilities and snacks. Show staff or mercenaries often guard these areas. What happens in the Green Room isn't broadcast by the show or the dungeon (but everything is still monitored), allowing crawlers, production staff, and other characters to speak more freely, though they're still monitored. Showrunners or Borant may censor things the audience can see as well.

THE SHOW ITSELF

For crawlers, most of the time the show takes place in a small production trailer, where many participants are represented by holograms similar to those that also make up most of the set dressing. Crawlers have a limited area to move around in these production trailers, and they're usually floating in the middle of an ocean, so don't get any crazy ideas about trying to break out.

RETURNING TO THE DUNGEON

After a crawler completes their time on the show, they're returned to the dungeon in the same place they were in when they left. Hopefully, it was somewhere safe! If not... eh, you'll figure it out, or you'll end up on another show in the highlight reel.

